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Identity Safety Cues in the Context of Confronting Prejudice: Black Americans' and Asian Americans' Perceptions of Identity Threat and Ally Sincerity

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Identity Safety Cues in the Context of Confronting Prejudice: Black Americans' and Asian Americans' Perceptions of Identity Threat and Ally Sincerity

Author Note

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Abstract

Environmental identity safety cues (ISCs), such as safe space posters, are used to signal support for marginalized groups. While environmental ISCs increase belonging and reduce identity threat, less is known about how they function alongside higher-cost ISCs such as prejudice confrontations. Across two experimental studies with Black Americans (n = 272), and Asian Americans (n = 279), we examined how environmental ISCs and confrontations jointly shape perceptions of Identity Threat and Ally Sincerity using a 2 (ISC: Present, Absent) x 2 (Confrontation: Present, Absent) between-subjects design. Results revealed that while ISCs can reduce Identity Threat and increase Ally Sincerity, prejudice confrontations are more consistent and effective. Additionally, there is no evidence for a backlash effect whereby having an ISC without a confrontation is worse than doing nothing. Results suggest U.S. racial minorities value confrontations and environmental ISCs, highlighting the importance of using both high- and low-cost prejudice reduction strategies.

Keywords: Identity safety cues, prejudice confrontations, identity safety, allyship, performative allyship

Identity Safety Cues in the Context of Confronting Prejudice: Black Americans' and Asian Americans' Perceptions of Identity Threat and Ally Sincerity

In the summer of 2020, the Black Lives Matter movement grew significantly in size and influence. People showed their support for this movement in a number of ways, ranging from more active and engaged actions such as demonstrating during the height of the COVID-19 pandemic to more passive actions. For instance, in June 2020, the posting and reposting of black squares with #BlackLivesMatter reflected what some believed to be a form of "performative activism," whereby allies of marginalized groups try to show support but do so in a manner that stems from a desire to be viewed as egalitarian and/or in a manner that does not truly advance and may even hurt the movement (Kalina, 2020; Kutlaca & Radke, 2023). Thus, what started as an act of protest by two Black women (i.e., #TheShowMustBePaused) was co-opted in a manner that produced shallow or even insincere results (Wellman, 2022). This incident, and others like it (e.g., corporations releasing diversity statements but reneging on those promises), pose an interesting question—how do U.S. racial minority group members perceive cues, meant to signal identity safety, if other more concrete actions are not taken? In the present research we examine this question by testing how the use (or not) of high-cost (i.e., confronting a prejudicial comment) and low-cost (i.e., displaying an identity safety cue poster) prejudice reduction strategies are judged in terms of identity threat and ally sincerity. Additionally, we test if there exists a backlash or *false cues* effect whereby only using the low-cost strategy may negatively impact U.S. racial minorities' perceptions.

Identity Safety Cues

According to Social Identity Theory (Steele et al., 2002) and the cues hypothesis (Murphy et al., 2007), marginalized group members encounter spaces and environments that can pose social evaluative threats based on their group membership. This threat can lead to a host of negative outcomes including lower academic and test performance (Mendoza-Denton et al., 2002; Steele & Aronson, 1995), higher physiological stress responses (Townsend et al., 2011),

lower motivation (Davies, et al., 2005) and reduced sense of belonging (Cohen & Garcia, 2008; Park et al., 2023; Steele et al., 2002). Prior work suggests that identity safety cues (ISCs), defined as "aspects of an environment or setting that signal to stigmatized groups that the threat of discrimination is limited and their social identities are welcome and valued" (Kruk & Matsick, 2021, p. 488) are one means of countering this threat (also see Pietri et al., 2025). ISCs can take multiple forms including diversity statements (Cipollina & Sanchez, 2019; Hall et al., 2018; Johnson & Pietri, 2025), group demographics (Pietri et al., 2018; Purdie-Vaughns et al., 2008), and confronting bias and prejudice (Hildebrand et al., 2020). Additionally, they can operate at multiple levels ranging from the interpersonal, such as one-on-one confrontations, to the institutional, such as a company including diversity efforts in its mission statement (Kruk & Matsick, 2021).

Environmental ISCs (e.g., posters, safe space stickers, flags, and symbols) are a type of ISC that describes features and objects within a space which serve as cues that one's identity is recognized and respected (Kruk & Matsick, 2021). Environmental ISCs can increase safety, belonging, and interest within stereotype threatening domains, in effect reducing social identity threat (Cheryan et al., 2009; Kruk & Matsick, 2021; Kruk et al., *in press*; Latu et al., 2013). For example, Chaney and Sanchez (2018) found that gender neutral, compared to binary gender, bathroom signs reduced women's anticipated stigma and increased perceived gender procedural fairness. These effects even transferred to racial minorities, who indicated greater trust and comfort in spaces with the gender neutral signs. Environmental ISCs have a number of advantages; they are relatively low cost, easy to implement, and applicable within multiple contexts such as schools (Cheryan et al., 2009), digital classrooms (Cheryan et al., 2011), and medical facilities (Cipollina & Sanchez, 2019). Even simple ISCs such as a doctor wearing a Black Lives Matter pin increased identity-safety compared to if no pin was displayed, especially

if the doctor was White (Derricks et al., 2022). Overall, environmental ISCs are effective, mitigating minority group members' concerns about being stereotyped, discriminated against, and encountering bias at relatively low cost and effort compared to other diversity enhancing strategies such as increasing the diversity of a company or interpersonally confronting bias. The simplicity of environmental ISCs, however, can be a double-edged sword leading to questions about the authenticity of the motives behind them.

Environmental Identity Safety Cues as Performative

The low cost and ease of implementation can lead to environmental ISCs being viewed as disingenuous or performative. That is, people may display or utilize environmental ISCs to seemingly show support for marginalized communities, yet might take these actions more to satisfy personal motivations such as appearing unprejudiced (Kutlaca & Radke, 2023). Indeed, the Black squares phenomenon was criticized because it required so little effort that people's motivations felt disingenuous, compared to the gravity of the issues, and that it caused harm by overtaking a grassroots movement (Wellman, 2022).

The existing literature on environmental ISCs has largely treated their use as faithful cues of allyship (Chaney & Sanchez, 2018; Cheryan et al., 2009, Latu et al., 2013). There is, however, little work examining how the presence of environmental ISCs influences evaluations if other, more costly, prejudice reduction behaviors are not taken. In this case, it is possible that the use of environmental ISCs without follow-up actions would backfire, increasing identity threat and decreasing perceptions of ally sincerity. Two lines of research support this assertion. First, work on diversity dishonesty demonstrates that companies and organizations which lie about their demographic representation are viewed negatively (Windscheid et al., 2016). For instance, Kroeper and colleagues (2022) found that if a company inauthentically states it is gender diverse, U.S. women rate this as insincere, which in turn increases identity concerns and reduces their

desire to work at the company. They also found significant direct effects whereby diversity dishonesty heightened women's identity threat concerns. Additionally, U.S. Black and Latine participants who view their workplace as dishonest about diversity perceive lower organizational fit and authenticity at work (Wilton et al., 2020). Overall, inauthentically representing an organization as diverse increases perceptions of diversity dishonesty and insincerity, leading to negative impressions, identity threat concerns, and worse workplace outcomes among marginalized group members.

Second, research shows that marginalized group members account for and favor actions that are effortful, costly, and concrete such as increasing the diversity of an organization, over more symbolic actions such as diversity statements (Derricks et al., 2023; Driskell & Trawalter, 2021; Ponce de Leon et al., 2024; Ragland & Sommers, 2024). For instance, when there is low minority representation, Black participants trust a company with a colorblind philosophy less, while no difference between colorblind and multicultural philosophies emerge for companies with high minority representation (Purdie-Vaughns et al., 2008). This suggests that when higher cost ISCs are missing (e.g., high racial diversity in an organization), marginalized group members are suspicious about the lack of other diversity-valuing information.

These findings align with theorizing on performative allyship which suggests that environmental ISCs which are not followed up by other actions will be viewed as ineffective and insincere because they are no longer a consistent cue of allyship and represent a low-cost strategy (Moser & Wiley, 2024). When evaluating ally behaviors, marginalized group members assess cost as a signal for the person's genuineness (Thai & Nylund, 2024), and internal motivation (Burns & Granz, 2023) and they desire more informed, direct, and selfless action (Bak et al., 2024; Brown & Ostrove, 2013; Park et al., 2022). When these factors are missing, allyship behaviors can increase anxiety and lower one's sense of safety (Collier-Spruel & Ryan,

2022). Consistency between what a cue represents and whether actions are taken that align with that cue matters. For instance, Moser and colleagues (2025) show that when a male colleague claims to be an ally but subsequently supports or ignores, compared to confronts, another colleague's sexist remark, women report lower identity-safety, perceived sincerity, and desire to work at the company. Overall, while environmental ISCs can bring about a number of positive consequences (Kruk & Matsick, 2021), they represent a low-cost strategy that may be viewed as a form of performative allyship, decreasing minority group members feelings that the person is truly an ally, and increasing identity threat, especially if they are not followed up by other actions.

Confronting Prejudice as an Identity Safety Cue

In contrast to environmental ISCs, the act of confronting bias and prejudice is a more direct yet costly prejudice reduction strategy which by itself can serve as an identity safety cue (Hildebrand et al., 2020; Monteith et al., 2022). Prior research finds that confronting bias is effective at reducing future stereotype use (Chaney et al., 2021; Chaney et al., 2025; Czopp et al., 2006; Wood et al., 2025) and signaling egalitarian norms (Chaney & Sanchez, 2018; Hildebrand et al., 2020; Parker et al., 2018). This action, however, is also associated with being viewed as a complainer and reduced likability (Alt et al., 2019; Czopp, 2019; Czopp & Monteith, 2003; Kaiser & Miller, 2001; Shelton & Stewart, 2004). Given that marginalized group members evaluate and value the genuineness of an ally's behavior based, in part, on how costly or effortful the action is perceived (Bak et al., 2024; Chu & Ashburn-Nardo, 2022; Thai & Nylund, 2024), assessing environmental ISCs and prejudice confrontations together allows us to examine how racial minority group members perceive the joint use of high- and low-cost strategies to address prejudice. Additionally, similar to Moser and colleagues' (2025) work on directly claiming ally status but not confronting a sexist statement, we examine whether there could be a backlash or

false cues effect whereby displaying an ISC but not confronting prejudice might hurt racial minorities' perceptions of allyship sincerity and increase identity threat.

Current Research

In two studies, we examine how Black Americans (Study 1) and Asian Americans (Study 2) evaluate a person who does or does not confront a prejudicial comment in the presence or absence of an environmental ISC.[1] We choose to examine reactions by members of these two groups to generalize beyond one racial minority and because of events which highlighted performative allyship (e.g., the Black squares during BLM (Wellman, 2022), and the use of #StopAAPIHate hashtag and yellow square posting (Frias, 2021). It is, however, critical to note that these groups have unique histories and face unique stereotypes, bias, prejudice, and challenges within the United States (Lei et al., 2023; Zou & Cheryan, 2017). Our outcomes focus on Identity Threat (i.e., perceived discrimination, bias recognition, and concern for belonging) and perceptions of Ally Sincerity (i.e., diversity dishonesty, suspicion of motives, and perceived allyship); as environmental ISCs, and more broadly prejudice reduction strategies, are meant to mitigate identity threat and showcase genuine support. Still, the ease of implementing environmental ISCs may lead them to be viewed as insincere, at least compared to more costly actions such as confronting bias. This work contributes to understanding how U.S. racial minority group members perceive the joint use of high- and low-cost prejudice reduction strategies as well as the possibility of a backlash, or false cues, effect whereby the use of a low-cost strategy and absence of a high-cost strategy is viewed as particularly insincere and unsafe. All data, materials, and pre-registrations are available at

[1] We also conducted an additional study prior to these studies (in Dec. 2022) examining White and Black Americans responses. Based in part on reviewer comments, space constraints, and given some methodological issues (i.e., no pre-registration and not using a full 2 (Confront: Yes, No) x 2 (ISC: Yes, No) design) we decided to report these findings in Supplemental Material.

https://osf.io/6rybw/?view_only=61eec5991dc549fca9bd22268e59d8c2. To gain a better understanding of the perspectives and positions we bring to this research please see our author notes. All procedures were approved by university Institutional Review Boards.

Study 1

In Study 1, we examined Black Americans' reactions to an individual who displays an ISC, or not, and confronts prejudice, or not. Based on prior research that examines environmental ISCs, confrontation, and performative allyship, we hypothesized a main effect of confronting prejudice such that the presence of a prejudice confrontation would decrease Identity Threat and increase Ally Sincerity. Additionally, we hypothesized a possible backlash effect for displaying an environmental ISC and not confronting prejudice. Specifically, in our pre-registration, we stated that participants would evaluate someone who displays an environmental ISC but does not confront, differently compared to the other conditions.

Method

Participants

In Fall 2024, we recruited participants through CloudResearch Connect (Hartman et al., 2023). Anticipating exclusions, we aimed to recruit 300 participants as power analyses in G*Power 3.1 (Faul et al., 2007) indicated a minimum of 256 participants to provide 80% power to detect an effect size of η_p^2 = .03. Ultimately, we recruited 305 Black Americans.[2] Thirty-three participants were excluded, 4 for identifying as non-Black and 29 for failing the manipulation check twice. This left a sample of 272 (M_{age} = 34.4, SD_{age} = 11.3, 162 women, 107 men, 2 gender unspecified, 1 non-binary).

[2] This number is slightly different from our pre-registration due to issues whereby the survey was started and then returned or timed out, so an additional participant was then recruited to reach the 300 participants on CloudResearch. We chose to include all possible completed data in our analyses.

Procedure and Materials

After providing informed consent, participants were randomized into one of four conditions: ISC present/Confront present, ISC present/Confront absent, ISC absent/Confront present, or ISC absent/Confront absent. In each condition, participants viewed a short video where they were told to imagine that they overheard a conversation between two work colleagues at company (see Figure 1 and OSF link for full videos). The video displayed the dialog, presented via text boxes (no audio) that appeared one at a time on the left or right of the screen. There were no pictures of the speakers just labels indicating the speaker (e.g., Colleague A and Colleague B). The background showcased an office which either had or did not have an environmental ISC (i.e., Fight Against Racism and a raised black fist poster or no poster). The office background depicts a personal space, as opposed to an institutional or company space (e.g., hallway), thus we conceptualized the environmental ISC as being attributed to Colleague A as opposed to the company. We did not measure whether participants attributed the ISC solely to Colleague A or the company although the video described the setting as "Colleague A's office". We return to this point more in the General Discussion.

In the dialog, Colleague B made a prejudicial/stereotypical statement (i.e., "Do you really think that a Black person would be up to it? Information Tech is central to the company's functioning and requires a lot of advanced qualifications"), to which Colleague A either confronted (i.e., "C'mon, Black people can be very qualified and capable! Your statements sound unfair and racist, don't you think?") or not, with no further dialogue (after that statement the video ends with "Colleague A notices you and waves you in while Colleague B leaves."). After viewing the video, participants completed manipulation checks regarding whether the comment was confronted or not and whether an environmental ISC was present or not. If participants failed the manipulation check on the first attempt they viewed the video again.

While we used a fairly overt form of confrontation and environmental ISC, a number of participants did not correctly answer the manipulation checks the first time (n = 83) however most correctly answered it the second time. As noted above, if participants failed the manipulation check twice, they were excluded (n = 29). After the video, participants completed all measures and demographic information, viewed a debrief, and were compensated $2.00.

Measures

We measured Identity Threat by assessing Perceived Discrimination, Bias Recognition, and Concern for Belonging and Ally Sincerity by assessing Diversity Dishonesty, Suspicion of Motives, and Perceived Allyship (see Supplemental Material (Supplemental Table 1) for correlations among measures). All items were on a 1 = "strongly disagree" to 7 = "strongly agree" Likert scale and presented in a randomized order.

Perceived Discrimination

We averaged five items assessing participants' judgments of Colleague A as discriminatory (see Sanchez et al., 2017, "How likely is Colleague A to discriminate against African Americans", α = .93).

Bias Recognition

We averaged three items assessing participants' beliefs that Colleague A recognizes bias (see Johnson & Pietri, 2022, "Most likely, Colleague A is aware of discrimination facing racial minorities", α = .95).

Concern for Belonging

We averaged six items assessing Concern for Belonging (see Kroeper et al., 2022, "How much might you worry that you wouldn't belong at this company", α = .96).

Diversity Dishonesty

We averaged three items assessing diversity dishonesty (see Wilton et al., 2020, "Colleague A is dishonest about how much they do to support diversity and inclusion", α = .89).

Suspicion of Motives Index

We calculated the Suspicion of Motives Index (Major et al., 2013) by subtracting Perceived Internal Motives (e.g., "Please indicate how much you agree or disagree with why Colleague A decorates their office the way they do: Because they value diversity", α = .91) from Perceived External Motives ("...Because they want to appear more socially progressive", α = .84). Scores ranged from -6 to 6. In this case, higher scores indicate more external versus internal motives to appear non-prejudiced (M = -0.09, SD = 2.04).

Perceived Allyship

We averaged two items assessing Perceived Allyship (see Pietri et al., 2018, "Most likely Colleague A cares about issues related to African Americans", r = .91).

Results

For each dependent variable, we conducted 2 (Confrontation: Yes, No) x 2 (ISC: Yes, No) between-subjects ANOVAs. We hypothesized participants would report lower Identity Threat (i.e., higher Perceived Discrimination, Concern for Belonging, and lower Bias Recognition) and higher Ally Sincerity (i.e., higher Diversity Dishonesty, Suspicion of Motives, and lower Perceived Allyship) when there was a confrontation compared to no confrontation. Additionally, we hypothesized a significant interaction such that participants would evaluate someone who does not confront but does display an identity safety cue differently compared to the other conditions. We report estimated marginal means and standard errors in the manuscript (see Table 1 for means and standard deviations).

Identity Threat Measures

For Perceived Discrimination, results revealed no significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 268) = 1.93$, $p = .165$, $\eta_p^2 = .01$, however there was a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 268) = 60.71$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .19$. Participants who viewed the confrontation had lower perceived discrimination scores ($M = 2.30$, $SE = 0.12$) compared to those who did not view the confrontation ($M = 3.61$, $SE = 0.12$). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 268) = 0.48$, $p = .488$, $\eta_p^2 = .002$.

For Bias Recognition, results revealed a significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 268) = 9.63$, $p = .002$, $\eta_p^2 = .04$, with higher bias recognition scores if there was an ISC ($M = 5.84$, $SE = 0.11$) compared to no ISC ($M = 5.36$, $SE = 0.11$). There was also a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 268) = 41.67$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .14$, with higher bias recognition scores if there was a confrontation ($M = 6.09$, $SE = 0.10$) compared to no confrontation ($M = 5.10$, $SE = 0.11$). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 268) = 0.03$, $p = .857$, $\eta_p^2 < .001$. We highlight this finding in Figure 2.

For Concern for Belonging, results revealed no significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 268) = 3.38$, $p = .067$, $\eta_p^2 = .01$. There was however a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 268) = 19.41$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .07$, such that the confrontation condition had lower concern for belonging scores ($M = 4.47$, $SE = 0.12$) compared to no confrontation ($M = 5.26$, $SE = 0.13$). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 268) = 0.14$, $p = .704$, $\eta_p^2 = .001$.

Ally Sincerity Measures

For Diversity Dishonesty, results revealed a marginally significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 268) = 3.59$, $p = .059$, $\eta_p^2 = .01$, such that an ISC reduced Diversity Dishonesty scores ($M = 3.90$, $SE = 0.12$) compared to no ISC ($M = 4.23$, $SE = 0.12$). There was a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 268) = 105.58$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .28$, with lower scores following a

confrontation (M = 3.16, SE = 0.12) compared to no confrontation (M = 4.96, SE = 0.13). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 268) = 0.002$, $p = .965$, $\eta_p^2 < .001$.

For Suspicion of Motives Index, results revealed a significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 268) = 8.35$, $p = .004$, $\eta_p^2 = .03$, with lower scores with an ISC (M = -0.34 SE = 0.16) compared to no ISC (M = 0.30, SE = 0.16). There was a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 268) = 65.30$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .20$, with lower scores following a confrontation (M = -0.91, SE = 0.15) compared to no confrontation (M = 0.87, SE = 0.16). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 268) = 0.10$, $p = .748$, $\eta_p^2 < .001$.

For Perceived Allyship, results revealed a significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 268) = 9.68$, $p = .002$, $\eta_p^2 = .04$, with higher scores with an ISC (M = 3.65, SE = .09) compared to no ISC (M = 3.27, SE = 0.09). There was a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 268) = 102.86$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .28$, with higher scores following a confrontation (M = 4.08, SE = 0.08) compared to no confrontation (M = 2.84, SE = 0.09). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 268) = 0.21$, $p = .646$, $\eta_p^2 = .001$. We highlight this finding in Figure 2.

Discussion

Results from Study 1 supported our first hypothesis; seeing someone confront a prejudicial comment, compared to no confrontation, reduced Identity Threat (i.e., lower Perceived Discrimination and Concern for Belonging scores and higher Bias Recognition scores) and increased Ally Sincerity (i.e., lower Diversity Dishonesty and Suspicion of Motives, and higher Perceived Allyship scores). Notably, we also found that an environmental ISC increased Bias Recognition and Perceived Allyship and decreased Suspicion of Motives (albeit with much smaller effect sizes compared to confronting prejudice), although it had no influence on Perceived Discrimination, Concern for Belonging, and only led to marginally statistically significant differences for Diversity Dishonesty. These findings highlight that while there is an

impact of ISCs, the act of confronting bias was a more powerful and consistent cue for Black Americans.

Notably, we did not find support for our hypothesis regarding a backlash or false cue effect. There was no statistically significant interaction across any of our variables. Thus, there is no evidence that displaying an ISC and not confronting prejudice led to statistically significantly worse outcomes in terms of Identity Threat or Ally Sincerity.

Study 2

In Study 2, we sought to increase the generalizability of our findings by examining reactions by members of another racial minority in the United States, Asian Americans. Asian Americans, while a heterogeneous group (Goh et al., 2023), still have a strong degree of perceived common fate and experiences (Ruiz et al., 2023). Additionally, the COVID-19 pandemic brought increased anti-Asian sentiment along with elements of performative allyship on social media (Frias, 2021). While we do not compare across racial minority groups, it is notable that similarities and differences can help to bring awareness to points of solidarity and interaction, particularly among groups that are at times pitted against each other (Alt et al., 2025). Thus, Study 2 closely mirrored Study 1, examining the effect of environmental ISCs and prejudice confrontation on Identity Threat and Ally Sincerity. We again hypothesized a main effect of prejudice confrontations decreasing Identity Threat and increasing perceptions of Ally Sincerity. While not found in Study 1, we also hypothesized a possible backlash effect for displaying an environmental ISC and not confronting prejudice.

Method

Participants

Anticipating exclusions, we aimed to recruit 300 participants as power analyses in G*Power 3.1 (Faul et al., 2007) indicated a minimum of 256 participants to provide 80% power

to detect an effect size of η_p^2 = .03. In Summer 2024, we recruited 311 Asian Americans. In total 32 participants were excluded, 12 for identifying as non-Asian and 20 for failing the manipulation check twice. This left a sample of 279 (M_{age} = 33.4, SD_{age} = 10.3, 117 women, 156 men, 3 gender unspecified, and 3 non-binary). Participants identified as the following: 74 Southeast Asians, 30 South Asians, 139 East Asians, 3 Pacific Islanders, 33 multiracial.

Procedure and Materials

The procedure closely mirrored Study 1. Participants, after providing informed consent, were randomized into one of four conditions: ISC present/Confront present, ISC present/Confront absent, ISC absent/Confront present, or ISC absent/Confront absent. The same situation was used where participants were told to imagine they overheard a conversation between two colleagues at work. Participants viewed a video that presented dialog between Colleague A and B via textboxes on the left or right of the screen (no audio or pictures of the speakers). The background either had, or did not have, an environmental ISC (i.e., Stop Asian Hate poster or no poster). The dialog contained a prejudicial/stereotypical comment by Colleague B (i.e., "...Asians aren't really good drivers typically, so, I'm just worried…"), to which Colleague A confronted (i.e., "Hey, that's just a stereotype. Some Asians are bad drivers, but some aren't. Just like other people. You can't assume she is going to be a bad driver just because she's Asian!") or not, after which the video ended. Participants then completed manipulation checks asking whether the comment was confronted or not and whether an environmental ISC was present or not. As in Study 1, participants who did not correctly answer the manipulation checks the first time (n = 80) rewatched the video, with 20 participants failing twice (as noted above these 20 were excluded). After the video, participants completed all measures and demographic information, were debriefed, and compensated $2.00.

The same measures were used as in Study 1 with appropriate adjustments (e.g., wording changed from African American to Asian American). These measures included: Perceived Discrimination (α = .93), Bias Recognition (α = .97), Concern for Belonging (α = .97), Diversity Dishonesty (α = .92), Suspicion of Motives (IMS, α = .95, EMS, α = .89, *M* = -0.06*, SD* = 1.68), and Perceived Allyship (*r* = .89). All measures were presented in a randomized order (see Supplemental Material (Supplemental Table 1) for correlations among measures).

Results

As in Study 1, we conducted 2 (Confrontation: Yes, No) x 2 (ISC: Yes, No) between-subjects ANOVAs. Our pre-registered hypotheses were the same as in Study 1. We predicted lower Identity Threat (i.e., higher Perceived Discrimination, Concern for Belonging, and lower Bias Recognition) and higher Ally Sincerity (i.e., higher Diversity Dishonesty, Suspicion of Motives, and lower Perceived Allyship) if there was a confrontation compared to not. We also hypothesized a significant interaction such that if someone displayed an ISC but did not confront they would be rated differently compared to the other conditions. We again report estimated marginal means and standard errors in the manuscript (see Table 1 for means and standard deviations).

Identity Threat Measures

For Perceived Discrimination, results revealed no significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 275) = 3.53$, $p = .062$, $\eta_p^2 = .01$, however there was a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 275) = 41.67$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .13$. Participants in the confrontation condition had lower perceived discrimination scores ($M = 2.20$, $SE = 0.11$) compared to those in the no confrontation condition ($M = 3.21$, $SE = 0.11$). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 275) = 0.26$, $p = .609$, $\eta_p^2 = .001$.

For Bias Recognition, results revealed no significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 275) = 0.73$, $p = .393$, $\eta_p^2 = .003$, however there was a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 275) = 72.28$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .21$, with higher bias recognition scores in the confrontation condition ($M = 5.77$, $SE = 0.10$) compared to no confrontation ($M = 4.49$, $SE = 0.11$). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 275) = 2.51$, $p = .114$, $\eta_p^2 = .01$. We highlight this finding in Figure 2.

For Concern for Belonging, results revealed no significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 275) = 1.18$, $p = .279$, $\eta_p^2 = .004$. There was, however, a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 275) = 5.07$, $p = .025$, $\eta_p^2 = .02$, such that the confrontation condition had lower concern for belonging scores ($M = 4.58$, $SE = 0.12$) compared to no confrontation ($M = 4.96$, $SE = 0.12$). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 275) = 0.36$, $p = .548$, $\eta_p^2 = .001$.

Ally Sincerity Measures

For Diversity Dishonesty, results revealed no significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 275) = 1.51$, $p = .221$, $\eta_p^2 = .01$. There was, however, a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 275) = 87.79$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .24$, with lower scores following a confrontation ($M = 3.08$, $SE = 0.11$) compared to no confrontation ($M = 4.57$, $SE = 0.12$). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 275) = 0.17$, $p = .683$, $\eta_p^2 = .001$.

For Suspicion of Motives Index, results revealed no significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 275) = 0.24$, $p = .628$, $\eta_p^2 = .001$. There was a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 275) = 54.41$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .17$, with lower scores following a confrontation ($M = -0.70$, $SE = 0.13$) compared to no confrontation ($M = 0.66$, $SE = 0.13$). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 275) = 1.06$, $p = .305$, $\eta_p^2 = .004$.

For Perceived Allyship, results revealed a significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 275) = 12.98$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .05$, with higher scores with an ISC ($M = 3.59$, $SE = .08$) compared to no ISC ($M = 3.20$, $SE = 0.08$). There was a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 275) = 102.43$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .27$, with higher scores following a confrontation ($M = 3.95$, $SE = 0.08$) compared to no confrontation ($M = 2.84$, $SE = 0.08$). These were qualified by a significant interaction, $F(1, 275) = 6.10$, $p = .014$, $\eta_p^2 = .02$. We highlight this finding in Figure 2.

We broke down this interaction by Confrontation condition. Results showed that when a confrontation was present, there was there was no significant simple main effect of ISC, $F(1, 275) = 0.68$, $p = .412$, $\eta_p^2 = .002$. There was, however, a significant simple main effect of ISC if the confrontation was absent, $F(1, 275) = 17.59$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .06$, such that seeing an ISC increased Perceived Allyship ($M = 3.18$, $SE = 0.11$) compared to when the ISC was absent ($M = 2.51$, $SE = 0.11$). These results suggest that ISCs become effective when higher-cost prejudice reduction strategies like confronting are not implemented. Still, this did not support our initial hypothesis that there would be a backlash or false cues effect; the ISC increased Perceived Allyship even though there was no confrontation.

Discussion

Study 2 showed, with a sample of Asian Americans, support across all measures that prejudice confrontations reduce Identity Threat and increase perceived Ally Sincerity. Our results also showed that an environmental ISC increased Perceived Allyship, particularly when there was no prejudice confrontation. This, however, was the only instance across Studies 1 and 2 of a statistically significant interaction between ISC and prejudice confrontation and in a direction that does not support a backlash/false cues effect. Thus, there appears limited evidence that having an ISC and not confronting prejudice produces negative effects for Identity Threat or Ally Sincerity compared to the other conditions. Additionally, while we did not design our

studies to be comparative, it is notable that we found fewer statistically significant main effects of the ISC across our dependent variables in Study 2 (only for Perceived Allyship) compared to Study 1 (i.e., Bias Recognition, Suspicion of Motives, and Perceived Allyship). We discuss this point more in the General Discussion.

General Discussion

Across two studies, we examined Black Americans' and Asian Americans' perceptions of the use of low- (i.e., environmental ISCs) and high-cost (i.e., confrontations) prejudice reduction strategies. Taken together, our results revealed that for both racial minority group members, prejudice confrontation mitigated Identity Threat (i.e., reduced perceived discrimination and concern for belonging and increased bias recognition) and increased perceived Ally Sincerity (i.e., reduced diversity dishonesty and suspicion of motives while increased perceived allyship). Environmental ISCs had more limited influence, specifically increasing bias recognition (Study 1), reducing suspicion of motives (Study 1) and increasing perceived allyship (Studies 1 and 2). While we hypothesized a possible backlash or false cues effect whereby having an environmental ISC without confronting a prejudicial statement would increase Identity Threat and decrease Ally Sincerity compared to the other conditions, particularly in the case of not confronting and not displaying an ISC, we did not find evidence for such a pattern.[3] Overall,

[3] Upon reflection, we recognized that our original pre-registered hypothesis was vaguely worded. A more specific test of the backlash/false cues effect would be to compare the ISC present/Confront absent and ISC absent/Confront absent conditions. As exploratory analyses we examined this using specific contrasts. For Study 1, results showed only a statistically significant contrast for Bias Recognition, $F(1, 268) = 5.02$, $p = .026$, $\eta_p^2 = .02$, whereby the ISC present/Confront absent condition had a higher score ($M = 5.35$, $SE = 0.16$) than the ISC absent/Confront absent condition ($M = 4.85$, $SE = 0.16$). For Study 2, there was a significant difference for Perceived Allyship between the two conditions, $F(1, 275) = 17.59$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .06$, whereby the ISC present/Confront absent ($M = 3.18$, $SE = 0.11$) was higher than the ISC absent/Confront absent ($M = 2.51$, $SE = 0.11$). In both cases, these results run counter to a backlash or false cues effect since the ISC present/Confront absent produced beneficial effects compared to the ISC absent/Confront absent condition.

these results highlight the importance of confronting prejudice and the critical, although weaker, role of environmental ISCs.

The current findings emerge amidst a U.S. political landscape in which diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) practices and policies are increasingly scrutinized and contested, harming the well-being of marginalized groups (Johnson, 2024; Kaur, 2025; Singh, 2025). As part of a growing effort to address psychological threats faced by marginalized people, identity safety cues (ISCs) have been presented as one implementable strategy (Kruk & Matsick, 2021). Still, while organizations and institutions, both in the U.S. and globally (Klapeer & Laskar, 2018), may display such symbols of inclusion, there is sometimes skepticism about the sincerity of such efforts, causing the action to be viewed as merely performative. This is especially true given the recent retreat of efforts around DEI practices. Our findings address this tension by examining the joint use of environmental ISCs and prejudice confrontations. Namely, we find that displaying environmental ISCs holds some value for minority perceivers by increasing their perception that the person is an ally and reducing identity threat. At the same time, our results show that taking more direct action such as confronting prejudice is even more effective.

At a policy level, our results indicate that organizations and policy makers should not dismiss the impact that environmental ISCs can have, however, they should not limit themselves to just this strategy. This is particularly relevant given new government restrictions which framed DEI programs and practices, including affirmative action and workplace training initiatives, as unlawful (Goldberg, 2025). Even with such constraints, organizations and institutions can play a role in educating individuals on effective approaches to confronting bias and discrimination. Our work highlights prejudice confrontations as a beneficial strategy for promoting inclusivity and belonging; thus, potential training programs could include information on considerations, how-to's, and different styles of confronting instances of bias (Chaney & Sanchez, 2022). Such

training can highlight that the onus to combat prejudice is not solely on marginalized individuals, but that the role allies play, including their motivations, is important (de Souza & Schmader, 2024; Moser & Wiley, 2024). While our work shows that individual actions are one key component to shaping perceptions of identity safety and ensuring that inclusion efforts extend beyond symbolic gestures, a growing body of work suggests that efforts by institutions also play a critical role (Wilton et al., in press).

Beyond its policy relevance, this work advances theoretical discussions on ISCs and prejudice confrontation in a number of ways. First, while early research rightfully examined whether environmental ISCs are effective at reducing identity threat and promoting identity safety (Chaney & Sanchez, 2018; Cheryan et al., 2009; Cipollina & Sanchez, 2019; Latu et al., 2013), our findings suggest that racial minorities may place different weights on different prejudice reduction strategies, valuing the higher cost strategy of confronting prejudice more than the lower cost strategy of an environmental ISC (Ponce de Leon et al., 2024; Thai & Nylund, 2024).

Second, our results also suggest limited evidence of a backlash or false cues effect. We find that displaying an ISC and not confronting a racist remark is no worse, and in some cases slightly better, than doing nothing (see Footnote 3). One speculative hypothesis for why no backlash effect emerged is that the environmental ISC could have been attributed to the organization and not the person. Since our measures, except for Concern for Belonging, focused on evaluating the person, it may be the case that participants thought the organization put up the environmental ISCs and not the individual. While we structured our videos to mitigate this concern such that the image showed a person's office and the office was stated as being Colleague A's, it may still be that participants believed the company put up the poster. In this case, it would make sense for participants to find no discrepancy between the person's displayed

ISC and their actions. The attribution of the environmental ISC to a different source may have ultimately reduced the possibility of finding a backlash effect.

Additionally, while we did not assess motives for putting up a poster or confronting bias, motives are important for perceptions of allyship behaviors (Chaney et al., *in press*; Chu & Ashburn-Nardo, 2022; Moser & Wiley, 2024; Radke et al., 2020; Thai & Nylund, 2024; Wilton et al., *in press*). One relevant and intriguing aspect of motives is that while one's motives, particularly regarding issues of bias and prejudice, can be difficult to know (Major et al., 2013; Rosenblum et al., 2022), racial minorities use attribution theory processes such as consistency (Kelley, 1973) to infer and draw conclusions about allies (Thai & Nylund, 2024). In our studies, behavior consistency was evident in the condition where the ISC and prejudice confrontation were both present. While we did not see this condition outperform the prejudice confrontation by itself, we would argue that seeing multiple cues that all align across time are valuable for reducing identity threat.

Constraints on Generality

This work was conducted in the U.S., and the meaning and cost of ISCs and prejudice confrontations may differ across cultural and sociopolitical contexts. Indeed, the ability to engage in direct confrontations is impacted by perceived social norms (Pereira-Jorge & Chaney, 2024), and thus the more liberal norms in the U.S. and broader Global North promote political correctness (i.e., norms against prejudice, discriminatory speech, or offensive views; Norris, 2021). These norms facilitate higher cost strategies despite the potential negative interpersonal consequences. In Global South and East Asian contexts, however, strategies like direct confrontation may be viewed as particularly high risk due to tighter norms around maintaining communal harmony (Lee et al., 2012). Thus, directly confronting someone about their attitudes may not be viewed as desirable or even an effective signal of ally sincerity. Our findings,

therefore, provide a starting point for expanding this work to other groups and locales. Future research could examine whether the perceived cost of ISCs is consistent across contexts, and whether individuals in different environments are more inclined to adopt lower cost strategies like signaling inclusion or utilize more indirect strategies.

Prior research also suggests that there is cultural variation in the extent to which people are motivated by self-enhancement, compared to self-effacement (Kitayama & Salvador, 2024), suggesting that the perceived authenticity of allyship behaviors may depend on cultural background. While the present work does not examine underlying motivations for displaying an ISC or confronting prejudice, recent work emphasizes the importance of motives within context (Louis et al., 2019; Ponce de Leon et al., 2024; Radke et al., 2020). For instance, the sincerity of an action may be judged based on whether it occurs in public or private. A higher cost strategy such as confronting prejudice might be seen as performative if carried out in the presence of others beyond the target of the confrontation. Future work should consider explicitly providing participants with information regarding ally motives for confronting (or not) and/or displaying an environmental ISC (or not). Indeed, this attribution of motive is important for understanding allyship behavior (Moser & Wiley, 2024; Nihill & Meyers, in press; Thai & Nylund, 2024), granted it is often difficult, if not impossible to know a person's true motives.

Other limitations of the current work apply to most studies that utilize hypothetical scenarios. For instance, we only used visually displayed posters even though there are other environmental ISCs such as diversity representation or pins on clothing (Derricks et al., 2022; Pietri et al., 2018; Purdie-Vaughns et al., 2008). Additionally, evidence suggests that the content of these cues matters for identity threat (Laiduc & Covarrubias, in press). While we attempted to keep the content of the posters similar across studies it is possible that the effectiveness of the environmental ISC differed, resulting in the inconsistent effects across Studies 1 and 2. For

instance, if Black participants viewed the poster as a more potent ISC, then this could account for why they had increased Bias Recognition, Perceived Allyship, and reduced Suspicion of Motives compared to the ISC only increasing Perceived Allyship for Asian American participants. We caution, however, that we did not design our studies to be explicitly comparative and rather sought to test two racial minority group members' reactions to generalize our findings. Future work could test different types of environmental ISCs to determine if some are more effective than others. Relatedly, we chose to use specific prejudicial remarks reliant on racial but also gendered stereotypes (i.e., STEM ability in Study 1 and driving in Study 2). While we found no consistent significant interactions with participant gender (see Supplemental Material for analyses), it should be noted that these remarks evoked gendered domains which might trigger intersectional stereotypes and prejudice (Ghavami & Peplau, 2012).

Conclusion

Environmental ISCs are used to signal identity safety, mitigate threat, and reduce marginalized group members' concerns that they will be the targets of bias and prejudice within a particular space (Kruk & Matsik, 2021). We show that U.S. racial minority group members, African Americans and Asian Americans, report reduced identity threat and increased ally sincerity when seeing a prejudice confrontation. Environmental ISCs are not to be ruled out since they are still effective compared to inaction. This research contributes to our understanding of how high- and low-cost prejudice reduction strategies operate in conjunction with each other, highlighting the importance of both in creating safe and inclusive climates.

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Table 1. Descriptive Means (*SDs*) for Studies 1 and 2 by Condition.

Figure 1. Images of the ISC Present/Confront Present conditions for Studies 1 and 2.

Figure 2. Results for Studies 1 (left) and 2 (right) for Perceived Allyship and Bias Recognition

Identity Safety Cues in the Context of Confronting Prejudice: Black Americans' and Asian Americans' Perceptions of Identity Threat and Ally Sincerity

Author Note

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Abstract

Environmental identity safety cues (ISCs), such as safe space posters, are used to signal support for marginalized groups. While environmental ISCs increase belonging and reduce identity threat, less is known about how they function alongside higher-cost ISCs such as prejudice confrontations. Across two experimental studies with Black Americans (n = 272), and Asian Americans (n = 279), we examined how environmental ISCs and confrontations jointly shape perceptions of Identity Threat and Ally Sincerity using a 2 (ISC: Present, Absent) x 2 (Confrontation: Present, Absent) between-subjects design. Results revealed that while ISCs can reduce Identity Threat and increase Ally Sincerity, prejudice confrontations are more consistent and effective. Additionally, there is no evidence for a backlash effect whereby having an ISC without a confrontation is worse than doing nothing. Results suggest U.S. racial minorities value confrontations and environmental ISCs, highlighting the importance of using both high- and low-cost prejudice reduction strategies.

Keywords: Identity safety cues, prejudice confrontations, identity safety, allyship, performative allyship

Identity Safety Cues in the Context of Confronting Prejudice: Black Americans' and Asian Americans' Perceptions of Identity Threat and Ally Sincerity

In the summer of 2020, the Black Lives Matter movement grew significantly in size and influence. People showed their support for this movement in a number of ways, ranging from more active and engaged actions such as demonstrating during the height of the COVID-19 pandemic to more passive actions. For instance, in June 2020, the posting and reposting of black squares with #BlackLivesMatter reflected what some believed to be a form of "performative activism," whereby allies of marginalized groups try to show support but do so in a manner that stems from a desire to be viewed as egalitarian and/or in a manner that does not truly advance and may even hurt the movement (Kalina, 2020; Kutlaca & Radke, 2023). Thus, what started as an act of protest by two Black women (i.e., #TheShowMustBePaused) was co-opted in a manner that produced shallow or even insincere results (Wellman, 2022). This incident, and others like it (e.g., corporations releasing diversity statements but reneging on those promises), pose an interesting question—how do U.S. racial minority group members perceive cues, meant to signal identity safety, if other more concrete actions are not taken? In the present research we examine this question by testing how the use (or not) of high-cost (i.e., confronting a prejudicial comment) and low-cost (i.e., displaying an identity safety cue poster) prejudice reduction strategies are judged in terms of identity threat and ally sincerity. Additionally, we test if there exists a backlash or *false cues* effect whereby only using the low-cost strategy may negatively impact U.S. racial minorities' perceptions.

Identity Safety Cues

According to Social Identity Theory (Steele et al., 2002) and the cues hypothesis (Murphy et al., 2007), marginalized group members encounter spaces and environments that can pose social evaluative threats based on their group membership. This threat can lead to a host of negative outcomes including lower academic and test performance (Mendoza-Denton et al., 2002; Steele & Aronson, 1995), higher physiological stress responses (Townsend et al., 2011),

lower motivation (Davies, et al., 2005) and reduced sense of belonging (Cohen & Garcia, 2008; Park et al., 2023; Steele et al., 2002). Prior work suggests that identity safety cues (ISCs), defined as "aspects of an environment or setting that signal to stigmatized groups that the threat of discrimination is limited and their social identities are welcome and valued" (Kruk & Matsick, 2021, p. 488) are one means of countering this threat (also see Pietri et al., 2025). ISCs can take multiple forms including diversity statements (Cipollina & Sanchez, 2019; Hall et al., 2018; Johnson & Pietri, 2025), group demographics (Pietri et al., 2018; Purdie-Vaughns et al., 2008), and confronting bias and prejudice (Hildebrand et al., 2020). Additionally, they can operate at multiple levels ranging from the interpersonal, such as one-on-one confrontations, to the institutional, such as a company including diversity efforts in its mission statement (Kruk & Matsick, 2021).

Environmental ISCs (e.g., posters, safe space stickers, flags, and symbols) are a type of ISC that describes features and objects within a space which serve as cues that one's identity is recognized and respected (Kruk & Matsick, 2021). Environmental ISCs can increase safety, belonging, and interest within stereotype threatening domains, in effect reducing social identity threat (Cheryan et al., 2009; Kruk & Matsick, 2021; Kruk et al., *in press*; Latu et al., 2013). For example, Chaney and Sanchez (2018) found that gender neutral, compared to binary gender, bathroom signs reduced women's anticipated stigma and increased perceived gender procedural fairness. These effects even transferred to racial minorities, who indicated greater trust and comfort in spaces with the gender neutral signs. Environmental ISCs have a number of advantages; they are relatively low cost, easy to implement, and applicable within multiple contexts such as schools (Cheryan et al., 2009), digital classrooms (Cheryan et al., 2011), and medical facilities (Cipollina & Sanchez, 2019). Even simple ~~cues~~ISCs such as a doctor wearing a Black Lives Matter pin increased identity-safety compared to if no pin was displayed, especially

if the doctor was White (Derricks et al., 2022). Overall, environmental ISCs are effective, mitigating minority group members' concerns about being stereotyped, discriminated against, and encountering bias at relatively low cost and effort compared to other diversity enhancing strategies such as increasing the diversity of a company or interpersonally confronting bias. The simplicity of environmental ISCs, however, can be a double-edged sword leading to questions about the authenticity of the motives behind them.

Environmental Identity Safety Cues as Performative

The low cost and ease of implementation can lead to environmental ISCs being viewed as disingenuous or performative. That is, people may display or utilize environmental ISCs to seemingly show support for marginalized communities, yet might take these actions more to satisfy personal motivations such as appearing unprejudiced (Kutlaca & Radke, 2023). Indeed, the Black squares phenomenon was criticized because it required so little effort that people's motivations felt disingenuous, compared to the gravity of the issues, and that it caused harm by overtaking a grassroots movement (Wellman, 2022).

The existing literature on environmental ISCs has largely treated their use as faithful cues of allyship (Chaney & Sanchez, 2018; Cheryan et al., 2009, Latu et al., 2013). There is, however, little work examining how the presence of environmental ISCs influences evaluations if other, more costly, prejudice reduction behaviors are not taken. In this case, it is possible that the use of environmental ISCs without follow-up actions would backfire, increasing identity threat and decreasing perceptions of ally sincerity. Two lines of research support this assertion. First, work on diversity dishonesty demonstrates that companies and organizations which lie about their demographic representation are viewed negatively (Windscheid et al., 2016). For instance, Kroeper and colleagues (2022) found that if a company inauthentically states it is gender diverse, U.S. women rate this as insincere, which in turn increases identity concerns and reduces their

desire to work at the company. They also found significant direct effects whereby diversity dishonesty heightened women's identity threat concerns. Additionally, U.S. Black and Latine participants who view their workplace as dishonest about diversity perceive lower organizational fit and authenticity at work (Wilton et al., 2020). Overall, inauthentically representing an organization as diverse increases perceptions of diversity dishonesty and insincerity, leading to negative impressions, identity threat concerns, and worse workplace outcomes among marginalized group members.

Second, research shows that marginalized group members account for and favor actions that are effortful, costly, and concrete such as increasing the diversity of an organization, over more symbolic actions such as diversity statements (Derricks et al., 2023; Driskell & Trawalter, 2021; Ponce de Leon et al., 2024; Ragland & Sommers, 2024). For instance, when there is low minority representation, Black participants trust a company with a colorblind philosophy less, while no difference between colorblind and multicultural philosophies emerge for companies with high minority representation (Purdie-Vaughns et al., 2008). This suggests that when higher cost ISCs are missing (e.g., high racial diversity in an organization), marginalized group members are suspicious about the lack of other diversity-valuing information.

These findings align with theorizing on performative allyship which suggests that environmental ISCs which are not followed up by other actions will be viewed as ineffective and insincere because they are no longer a consistent cue of allyship and represent a low-cost strategy (Moser & Wiley, 2024). When evaluating ally behaviors, marginalized group members assess cost as a signal for the person's genuineness (Thai & Nylund, 2024), and internal motivation (Burns & Granz, 2023) and they desire more informed, direct, and selfless action (Bak et al., 2024; Brown & Ostrove, 2013; Park et al., 2022). When these factors are missing, allyship behaviors can increase anxiety and lower one's sense of safety (Collier-Spruel & Ryan,

2022). Consistency between what a cue represents and whether actions are taken that align with that cue matters. For instance, Moser and colleagues (2025) show that when a male colleague claims to be an ally but subsequently supports or ignores, compared to confronts, another colleague's sexist remark, women report lower identity-safety, perceived sincerity, and desire to work at the company. Overall, while environmental ISCs can bring about a number of positive consequences (Kruk & Matsick, 2021), they represent a low-cost strategy that may be viewed as a form of performative allyship, decreasing minority group members feelings that the person is truly an ally, and increasing identity threat, especially if they are not followed up by other actions.

~~Confrontational Behavior~~Confronting Prejudice as an Identity Safety Cue

In contrast to environmental ISCs, the act of confronting bias and prejudice is a more direct yet costly prejudice reduction strategy which by itself can serve as an identity safety cue (Hildebrand et al., 2020; Monteith et al., 2022). Prior research finds that confronting bias is effective at reducing future stereotype use (Chaney et al., 2021; Chaney et al., 2025; Czopp et al., 2006; Wood et al., 2025) and signaling egalitarian norms (Chaney & Sanchez, 2018; Hildebrand et al., 2020; Parker et al., 2018). This action, however, is also associated with being viewed as a complainer and reduced likability (Alt et al., 2019; Czopp, 2019; Czopp & Monteith, 2003; Kaiser & Miller, 2001; Shelton & Stewart, 2004). Given that marginalized group members evaluate and value the genuineness of an ally's behavior based, in part, on how costly or effortful the action is perceived (Bak et al., 2024; Chu & Ashburn-Nardo, 2022; Thai & Nylund, 2024), assessing environmental ISCs and prejudice confrontations together allows us to examine how racial minority group members perceive the joint use of high- and low-cost strategies to address prejudice. Additionally, similar to Moser and colleagues' (2025) work on directly claiming ally status but not confronting a sexist statement, we examine whether there could be a backlash or

false cues effect whereby displaying an ISC but not confronting prejudice might hurt racial minorities' perceptions of allyship sincerity and increase identity threat.

Current Research

In two studies, we examine how Black Americans (Study 1) and Asian Americans (Study 2) evaluate a person who does or does not confront a prejudicial comment in the presence or absence of an environmental ISC.[1] We choose to examine reactions by members of these two groups to generalize beyond one racial minority and because of events which highlighted performative allyship (e.g., the Black squares during BLM (Wellman, 2022), and the use of #StopAAPIHate hashtag and yellow square posting (Frias, 2021~~)).~~). It is, however, critical to note that these groups have unique histories and face unique stereotypes, bias, prejudice, and challenges within the United States (Lei et al., 2023; Zou & Cheryan, 2017). Our outcomes focus on Identity Threat (i.e., perceived discrimination, bias recognition, and concern for belonging) and perceptions of ~~ally~~Ally Sincerity (i.e., diversity dishonesty, suspicion of motives, and perceived allyship); as environmental ISCs, and more broadly prejudice reduction strategies, are meant to mitigate identity threat and showcase genuine support. Still, the ease of implementing environmental ISCs may lead them to be viewed as insincere, at least compared to more costly actions such as confronting bias. This work contributes to understanding how U.S. racial minority group members perceive the joint use of high- and low-cost prejudice reduction strategies as well as the possibility of a backlash, or false cues, effect whereby the use of a low-cost strategy and absence of a high-cost strategy is viewed as particularly insincere and unsafe. All data, materials, and pre-registrations are available at

[1] We also conducted an additional study prior to these studies (in Dec. 2022) examining White and Black Americans responses. Based in part on reviewer comments, space constraints, and given some methodological issues (i.e., no pre-registration and not using a full 2 (Confront: Yes, No) x 2 (ISC: Yes, No) design) we decided to report these findings in Supplemental Material.

https://osf.io/6rybw/?view_only=61eec5991dc549fca9bd22268e59d8c2. To gain a better understanding of the perspectives and positions we bring to this research please see our author notes. All procedures were approved by university Institutional Review Boards.

Study 1

In Study 1, we examined Black Americans' reactions to an individual who displays an ISC, or not, and confronts prejudice, or not. Based on prior research that examines environmental ISCs, confrontation, and performative allyship, we hypothesized a main effect of confronting prejudice such that the presence of a prejudice confrontation would decrease Identity Threat and increase Ally Sincerity. Additionally, we hypothesized a possible backlash effect for displaying an environmental ISC and not confronting prejudice. Specifically, in our pre-registration, we stated that participants would evaluate someone who displays an environmental ISC but does not confront, differently compared to the other conditions.

Method

Participants

In Fall 2024, we recruited participants through CloudResearch Connect (Hartman et al., 2023). Anticipating exclusions, we aimed to recruit 300 participants as power analyses in G*Power 3.1 (Faul et al., 2007) indicated a minimum of 256 participants to provide 80% power to detect an effect size of η_p^2 = .03. Ultimately, we recruited 305 Black Americans.[2] Thirty-three participants were excluded, 4 for identifying as non-Black and 29 for failing the manipulation check twice. This left a sample of 272 (M_{age} = 34.4, SD_{age} = 11.3, 162 women, 107 men, 2 gender unspecified, 1 non-binary).

[2] This number is slightly different from our pre-registration due to issues whereby the survey was started and then returned or timed out, so an additional participant was then recruited to reach the 300 participants on CloudResearch. We chose to include all possible completed data in our analyses.

Procedure and Materials

After providing informed consent, participants were randomized into one of four conditions: ISC present/Confront present, ISC present/Confront absent, ISC absent/Confront present, or ISC absent/Confront absent. In each condition, participants viewed a short video where they were told to imagine that they overheard a conversation between two work colleagues at company (see Figure 1 and OSF link for full videos). The video displayed the dialog, presented via text boxes (no audio) that appeared one at a time on the left or right of the screen. There were no pictures of the speakers just labels indicating the speaker (e.g., Colleague A and Colleague B). The background showcased an office which either had or did not have an environmental ISC (i.e., Fight Against Racism and a raised black fist poster or no poster). The office background depicts a personal space, as opposed to an institutional or company space (e.g., hallway), thus we conceptualized the environmental ISC as being attributed to Colleague A as opposed to the company. We did not measure whether participants attributed the ISC solely to Colleague A or the company although the video described the setting as "Colleague A's office". We return to this point more in the General Discussion.

In the dialog, Colleague B ~~would make~~made a prejudicial/stereotypical statement (i.e., "Do you really think that a Black person would be up to it? Information Tech is central to the company's functioning and requires a lot of advanced qualifications"), to which Colleague A ~~would~~ either ~~confront~~confronted (i.e., "C'mon, Black people can be very qualified and capable! Your statements sound unfair and racist, don't you think?") or not, with no further dialogue (after that statement the video ends with "Colleague A notices you and waves you in while Colleague B leaves."). After viewing the video, participants completed manipulation checks regarding whether the comment was confronted or not and whether an environmental ISC was present or not. If participants failed the manipulation check on the first attempt they viewed the

video again. While we used a fairly overt form of confrontation and environmental ISC, a number of participants did not correctly answer the manipulation checks the first time (n = 83) however most correctly answered it the second time. As noted above, if participants failed the manipulation check twice, they were excluded (n = 29). After the video, participants completed all measures and demographic information, viewed a debrief, and were compensated $2.00.

Measures

We measured Identity Threat by assessing Perceived Discrimination, Bias Recognition, and Concern for Belonging and Ally Sincerity by assessing Diversity Dishonesty, Suspicion of Motives, and Perceived Allyship (see Supplemental Material (Supplemental Table 1) for correlations among measures). All items were on a 1 = "strongly disagree" to 7 = "strongly agree" Likert scale and presented in a randomized order.

Perceived Discrimination

We averaged five items assessing participants' judgments of Colleague A as discriminatory (see Sanchez et al., 2017, "How likely is Colleague A to discriminate against African Americans", α = .93).

Bias Recognition

We averaged three items assessing participants' beliefs that Colleague A recognizes bias (see Johnson & Pietri, 2022, "Most likely, Colleague A is aware of discrimination facing racial minorities", α = .95).

Concern for Belonging

We averaged six items assessing Concern for Belonging (see Kroeper et al., 2022, "How much might you worry that you wouldn't belong at this company", α = .96).

Diversity Dishonesty

We averaged three items assessing diversity dishonesty (see Wilton et al., 2020, "Colleague A is dishonest about how much they do to support diversity and inclusion", α = .89).

Suspicion of Motives Index

We calculated the Suspicion of Motives Index (Major et al., 2013) by subtracting Perceived Internal Motives (e.g., "Please indicate how much you agree or disagree with why Colleague A decorates their office the way they do: Because they value diversity", α = .91) from Perceived External Motives ("...Because they want to appear more socially progressive", α = .84). Scores ranged from -6 to 6. In this case, higher scores indicate more external versus internal motives to appear non-prejudiced (*M* = -0.09, *SD* = 2.04).

Perceived Allyship

We averaged two items assessing Perceived Allyship (see Pietri et al., 2018, "Most likely Colleague A cares about issues related to African Americans", *r* = .91).

Results

For each dependent variable, we conducted 2 (Confrontation: Yes, No) x 2 (ISC: Yes, No) between-subjects ANOVAs. We hypothesized participants would report lower Identity Threat (i.e., higher Perceived Discrimination, Concern for Belonging, and lower Bias Recognition) and higher Ally Sincerity (i.e., higher Diversity Dishonesty, Suspicion of Motives, and lower Perceived Allyship) when there ~~is~~was a confrontation compared to no confrontation. Additionally, we hypothesized a significant interaction such that participants would evaluate someone who does not confront but does display an identity safety cue differently compared to the other conditions. We report estimated marginal means and standard errors in the manuscript (see Table 1 for means and standard deviations).

Identity Threat Measures

For Perceived Discrimination, results revealed no significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 268) = 1.93$, $p = .165$, $\eta_p^2 = .01$, however there was a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 268) = 60.71$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .19$. Participants who viewed the confrontation had lower perceived discrimination scores ($M = 2.30$, $SE = 0.12$) compared to those who did not view the confrontation ($M = 3.61$, $SE = 0.12$). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 268) = 0.48$, $p = .488$, $\eta_p^2 = .002$.

For Bias Recognition, results revealed a significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 268) = 9.63$, $p = .002$, $\eta_p^2 = .04$, with higher bias recognition scores if there was an ISC ($M = 5.84$, $SE = 0.11$) compared to no ISC ($M = 5.36$, $SE = 0.11$). There was also a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 268) = 41.67$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .14$, with higher bias recognition scores if there was a confrontation ($M = 6.09$, $SE = 0.10$) compared to no confrontation ($M = 5.10$, $SE = 0.11$). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 268) = 0.03$, $p = .857$, $\eta_p^2 < .001$. We highlight this finding in Figure 2.

For Concern for Belonging, results revealed no significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 268) = 3.38$, $p = .067$, $\eta_p^2 = .01$. There was however a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 268) = 19.41$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .07$, such that the confrontation condition had lower concern for belonging scores ($M = 4.47$, $SE = 0.12$) compared to no confrontation ($M = 5.26$, $SE = 0.13$). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 268) = 0.14$, $p = .704$, $\eta_p^2 = .001$.

Ally Sincerity Measures

For Diversity Dishonesty, results revealed a marginally significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 268) = 3.59$, $p = .059$, $\eta_p^2 = .01$, such that an ISC reduced Diversity Dishonesty scores ($M = 3.90$, $SE = 0.12$) compared to no ISC ($M = 4.23$, $SE = 0.12$). There was a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 268) = 105.58$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .28$, with lower scores following a

confrontation (M = 3.16, SE = 0.12) compared to no confrontation (M = 4.96, SE = 0.13). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 268) = 0.002$, $p = .965$, $\eta_p^2 < .001$.

For Suspicion of Motives Index, results revealed a significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 268) = 8.35$, $p = .004$, $\eta_p^2 = .03$, with lower scores with an ISC (M = -0.34 SE = 0.16) compared to no ISC (M = 0.30, SE = 0.16). There was a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 268) = 65.30$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .20$, with lower scores following a confrontation (M = -0.91, SE = 0.15) compared to no confrontation (M = 0.87, SE = 0.16). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 268) = 0.10$, $p = .748$, $\eta_p^2 < .001$.

For Perceived Allyship, results revealed a significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 268) = 9.68$, $p = .002$, $\eta_p^2 = .04$, with higher scores with an ISC (M = 3.65, SE = .09) compared to no ISC (M = 3.27, SE = 0.09). There was a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 268) = 102.86$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .28$, with higher scores following a confrontation (M = 4.08, SE = 0.08) compared to no confrontation (M = 2.84, SE = 0.09). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 268) = 0.21$, $p = .646$, $\eta_p^2 = .001$. We highlight this finding in Figure 2.

Discussion

Results from Study 1 supported our first hypothesis; seeing someone confront a prejudicial comment, compared to no confrontation, reduced Identity Threat (i.e., lower Perceived Discrimination and Concern for Belonging scores and higher Bias Recognition scores) and increased Ally Sincerity (i.e., lower Diversity Dishonesty and Suspicion of Motives, and higher Perceived Allyship scores). Notably, we also found that an environmental ISC increased Bias Recognition and Perceived Allyship and decreased Suspicion of Motives (albeit with much smaller effect sizes compared to confronting prejudice), although it had no influence on Perceived Discrimination, Concern for Belonging, and only led to marginally statistically significant differences for Diversity Dishonesty. These findings highlight that while there is an

impact of ISCs, the act of confronting bias was a more powerful and consistent cue for Black Americans.

Notably, we did not find support for our hypothesis regarding a backlash or false cue effect. There was no statistically significant interaction across any of our variables. Thus, there is no evidence that displaying an ISC and not confronting prejudice led to statistically significantly worse outcomes in terms of Identity Threat or Ally Sincerity.

Study 2

In Study 2, we sought to increase the generalizability of our findings by examining reactions by members of another racial minority in the United States, Asian Americans. Asian Americans, while a heterogeneous group (Goh et al., 2023), still have a strong degree of perceived common fate and experiences (Ruiz et al., 2023). Additionally, the COVID-19 pandemic brought increased anti-Asian sentiment along with elements of performative allyship on social media (Frias, 2021). While we do not compare across racial minority groups, it is notable that similarities and differences can help to bring awareness to points of solidarity and interaction, particularly among groups that are at times pitted against each other (Alt et al., 2025). Thus, Study 2 closely mirrored Study 1, examining the effect of environmental ISCs and prejudice confrontation on Identity Threat and Ally Sincerity. We again hypothesized a main effect of prejudice confrontations decreasing Identity Threat and increasing perceptions of Ally Sincerity. While not found in Study 1, we also hypothesized a possible backlash effect for displaying an environmental ISC and not confronting prejudice.

Method

Participants

Anticipating exclusions, we aimed to recruit 300 participants as power analyses in G*Power 3.1 (Faul et al., 2007) indicated a minimum of 256 participants to provide 80% power

to detect an effect size of η_p^2 = .03. In Summer 2024, we recruited 311 Asian Americans. In total 32 participants were excluded, 12 for identifying as non-Asian and 20 for failing the manipulation check twice. This left a sample of 279 (M_{age} = 33.4, SD_{age} = 10.3, 117 women, 156 men, 3 gender unspecified, and 3 non-binary). Participants identified as the following: 74 Southeast Asians, 30 South Asians, 139 East Asians, 3 Pacific Islanders, 33 multiracial.

Procedure and Materials

The procedure closely mirrored Study 1. Participants, after providing informed consent, were randomized into one of four conditions: ISC present/Confront present, ISC present/Confront absent, ISC absent/Confront present, or ISC absent/Confront absent. The same situation was used where participants were told to imagine they overheard a conversation between two colleagues at work. Participants viewed a video that presented dialog between Colleague A and B via textboxes on the left or right of the screen (no audio or pictures of the speakers). The background either had, or did not have, an environmental ISC (i.e., Stop Asian Hate poster or no poster). The dialog contained a prejudicial/stereotypical comment by Colleague B (i.e., "...Asians aren't really good drivers typically, so, I'm just worried…"), to which Colleague A confronted (i.e., "Hey, that's just a stereotype. Some Asians are bad drivers, but some aren't. Just like other people. You can't assume she is going to be a bad driver just because she's Asian!") or not, after which the video ended. Participants then completed manipulation checks asking whether the comment was confronted or not and whether an environmental ISC was present or not. As in Study 1, participants who did not correctly answer the manipulation checks the first time (n = 80) rewatched the video, with 20 participants failing twice (as noted above these 20 were excluded). After the video, participants completed all measures and demographic information, were debriefed, and compensated $2.00.

The same measures were used as in Study 1 with appropriate adjustments (e.g., wording changed from African American to Asian American). These measures included: Perceived Discrimination (α = .93), Bias Recognition (α = .97), Concern for Belonging (α = .97), Diversity Dishonesty (α = .92), Suspicion of Motives (IMS, α = .95, EMS, α = .89, *M* = -0.06, *SD* = 1.68), and Perceived Allyship (*r* = .89). All measures were presented in a randomized order (see Supplemental Material (Supplemental Table 1) for correlations among measures).

Results

As in Study 1, we conducted 2 (Confrontation: Yes, No) x 2 (ISC: Yes, No) between-subjects ANOVAs. Our pre-registered hypotheses were the same as in Study 1. We predicted lower Identity Threat (i.e., higher Perceived Discrimination, Concern for Belonging, and lower Bias Recognition) and higher Ally Sincerity (i.e., higher Diversity Dishonesty, Suspicion of Motives, and lower Perceived Allyship) if there was a confrontation compared to not. We also hypothesized a significant interaction such that if someone displayed an ISC but did not confront they would be rated differently compared to the other conditions. We again report estimated marginal means and standard errors in the manuscript (see Table 1 for means and standard deviations).

Identity Threat Measures

For Perceived Discrimination, results revealed no significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 275) = 3.53$, $p = .062$, $\eta_p^2 = .01$, however there was a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 275) = 41.67$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .13$. Participants in the confrontation condition had lower perceived discrimination scores ($M = 2.20$, $SE = 0.11$) compared to those in the no confrontation condition ($M = 3.21$, $SE = 0.11$). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 275) = 0.26$, $p = .609$, $\eta_p^2 = .001$.

For Bias Recognition, results revealed no significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 275) = 0.73$, $p = .393$, $\eta_p^2 = .003$, however there was a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 275) = 72.28$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .21$, with higher bias recognition scores in the confrontation condition ($M = 5.77$, $SE = 0.10$) compared to no confrontation ($M = 4.49$, $SE = 0.11$). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 275) = 2.51$, $p = .114$, $\eta_p^2 = .01$. We highlight this finding in Figure 2.

For Concern for Belonging, results revealed no significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 275) = 1.18$, $p = .279$, $\eta_p^2 = .004$. There was, however, a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 275) = 5.07$, $p = .025$, $\eta_p^2 = .02$, such that the confrontation condition had lower concern for belonging scores ($M = 4.58$, $SE = 0.12$) compared to no confrontation ($M = 4.96$, $SE = 0.12$). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 275) = 0.36$, $p = .548$, $\eta_p^2 = .001$.

Ally Sincerity Measures

For Diversity Dishonesty, results revealed no significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 275) = 1.51$, $p = .221$, $\eta_p^2 = .01$. There was, however, a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 275) = 87.79$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .24$, with lower scores following a confrontation ($M = 3.08$, $SE = 0.11$) compared to no confrontation ($M = 4.57$, $SE = 0.12$). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 275) = 0.17$, $p = .683$, $\eta_p^2 = .001$.

For Suspicion of Motives Index, results revealed no significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 275) = 0.24$, $p = .628$, $\eta_p^2 = .001$. There was a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 275) = 54.41$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .17$, with lower scores following a confrontation ($M = -0.70$, $SE = 0.13$) compared to no confrontation ($M = 0.66$, $SE = 0.13$). There was no significant interaction, $F(1, 275) = 1.06$, $p = .305$, $\eta_p^2 = .004$.

For Perceived Allyship, results revealed a significant main effect of ISC, $F(1, 275) = 12.98$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .05$, with higher scores with an ISC ($M = 3.59$, $SE = .08$) compared to no ISC ($M = 3.20$, $SE = 0.08$). There was a significant main effect of Confrontation, $F(1, 275) = 102.43$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .27$, with higher scores following a confrontation ($M = 3.95$, $SE = 0.08$) compared to no confrontation ($M = 2.84$, $SE = 0.08$). These were qualified by a significant interaction, $F(1, 275) = 6.10$, $p = .014$, $\eta_p^2 = .02$. We highlight this finding in Figure 2.

We broke down this interaction by Confrontation condition. Results showed that when a confrontation was present, there was there was no significant simple main effect of ISC, $F(1, 275) = 0.68$, $p = .412$, $\eta_p^2 = .002$. There was, however, a significant simple main effect of ISC if the confrontation was absent, $F(1, 275) = 17.59$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .06$, such that seeing an ISC increased Perceived Allyship ($M = 3.18$, $SE = 0.11$) compared to when the ISC was absent ($M = 2.51$, $SE = 0.11$). These results suggest that ISCs become effective when higher-cost prejudice reduction strategies like confronting are not implemented. Still, this did not support our initial hypothesis that there would be a backlash or false cues effect; the ISC increased Perceived Allyship even though there was no confrontation.

Discussion

Study 2 showed, with a sample of Asian Americans, support across all measures that prejudice confrontations reduce Identity Threat and increase perceived ~~ally~~Ally Sincerity. Our results also showed that an environmental ISC increased Perceived Allyship, particularly when there was no prejudice confrontation. This, however, was the only instance across Studies 1 and 2 of a statistically significant interaction between ISC and prejudice confrontation and in a direction that does not support a backlash/false cues effect. Thus, there appears limited evidence that having an ISC and not confronting prejudice produces negative effects for Identity Threat or Ally Sincerity compared to the other conditions. Additionally, while we did not design our

studies to be comparative, it is notable that we found fewer statistically significant main effects of the ISC across our dependent variables in Study 2 (only for Perceived Allyship) compared to Study 1 (i.e., Bias Recognition, Suspicion of Motives, and Perceived Allyship). We discuss this point more in the General Discussion.

General Discussion

Across two studies, we examined Black Americans' and Asian Americans' perceptions of the use of low- (i.e., environmental ISCs) and high-cost (i.e., confrontations) prejudice reduction strategies. Taken together, our results revealed that for both racial minority group members, prejudice confrontation mitigated Identity Threat (i.e., reduced perceived discrimination and concern for belonging and increased bias recognition) and increased perceived Ally Sincerity (i.e., reduced diversity dishonesty and suspicion of motives while increased perceived allyship). Environmental ISCs had more limited influence, specifically increasing bias recognition (Study 1), reducing suspicion of motives (Study 1) and increasing perceived allyship (Studies 1 and 2). While we hypothesized a possible backlash or false cues effect whereby having an environmental ISC without confronting a prejudicial statement would increase Identity Threat and decrease Ally Sincerity compared to the other conditions, particularly in the case of not confronting and not displaying an ISC, we did not find evidence for such a pattern.[3] Overall,

[3] Upon reflection, we recognized that our original pre-registered hypothesis was vaguely worded. A more specific test of the backlash/false cues effect would be to compare the ISC present/Confront absent and ISC absent/Confront absent conditions. As exploratory analyses we examined this using specific contrasts. For Study 1, results showed only a statistically significant contrast for Bias Recognition, $F(1, 268) = 5.02$, $p = .026$, $\eta_p^2 = .02$, whereby the ISC present/Confront absent condition had a higher score ($M = 5.35$, $SE = 0.16$) than the ISC absent/Confront absent condition ($M = 4.85$, $SE = 0.16$). For Study 2, there was a significant difference for Perceived Allyship between the two conditions, $F(1, 275) = 17.59$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .06$, whereby the ISC present/Confront absent ($M = 3.18$, $SE = 0.11$) was higher than the ISC absent/Confront absent ($M = 2.51$, $SE = 0.11$). In both cases, these results run counter to a backlash or false cues effect since the ISC present/Confront absent produced beneficial effects compared to the ISC absent/Confront absent condition.

these results highlight the importance of confronting prejudice and the critical, although weaker, role of environmental ISCs.

The current findings emerge amidst a U.S. political landscape in which diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) practices and policies are increasingly scrutinized and contested, harming the well-being of marginalized groups (Johnson, 2024; Kaur, 2025; Singh, 2025). As part of a growing effort to address psychological threats faced by marginalized people, identity safety cues (ISCs) have been presented as one implementable strategy (Kruk & Matsick, 2021). Still, while organizations and institutions, both in the U.S. and globally (Klapeer & Laskar, 2018), may display such symbols of inclusion, there is sometimes skepticism about the sincerity of such efforts, causing the action to be viewed as merely performative. This is especially true given the recent retreat of efforts around DEI practices. Our findings address this tension by examining the joint use of environmental ISCs and prejudice confrontations. Namely, we find that displaying environmental ISCs holds some value for minority perceivers by increasing their perception that the person is an ally and reducing identity threat. At the same time, our results show that taking more direct action such as confronting prejudice is even more effective.

At a policy level, our results indicate that organizations and policy makers should not dismiss the impact that environmental ISCs can have, however, they should not limit themselves to just this strategy. This is particularly relevant given new government restrictions which framed DEI programs and practices, including affirmative action and workplace training initiatives, as unlawful (Goldberg, 2025). Even with such constraints, organizations and institutions can play a role in educating individuals on effective approaches to confronting bias and discrimination. Our work highlights prejudice confrontations as a beneficial strategy for promoting inclusivity and belonging; thus, potential training programs could include information on considerations, how-to's, and different styles of confronting instances of bias (Chaney & Sanchez, 2022). Such

training can highlight that the onus to combat prejudice is not solely on marginalized individuals, but that the role allies play, including their motivations, is important (de Souza & Schmader, 2024; Moser & Wiley, 2024). While our work shows that individual actions are one key component to shaping perceptions of identity safety and ensuring that inclusion efforts extend beyond symbolic gestures, a growing body of work suggests that efforts by institutions also play a critical role (Wilton et al., in press).

Beyond its policy relevance, this work advances theoretical discussions on ISCs and prejudice confrontation in a number of ways. First, while early research rightfully examined whether environmental ISCs are effective at reducing identity threat and promoting identity safety (Chaney & Sanchez, 2018; Cheryan et al., 2009; Cipollina & Sanchez, 2019; Latu et al., 2013), our findings suggest that racial minorities may place different weights on different prejudice reduction strategies, valuing the higher cost strategy of confronting prejudice more than the lower cost strategy of an environmental ISC (Ponce de Leon et al., 2024; Thai & Nylund, 2024).

Second, our results also suggest limited evidence of a backlash or false cues effect. We find that displaying an ISC and not confronting a racist remark is no worse, and in some cases slightly better, than doing nothing (see Footnote 3). One speculative hypothesis for why no backlash effect emerged is that the environmental ISC could have been attributed to the organization and not the person. Since our measures, except for Concern for Belonging, focused on evaluating the person, it may be the case that participants thought the organization put up the environmental ISCs and not the individual. While we structured our videos to mitigate this concern such that the image showed a person's office and the office was stated as being Colleague A's, it may still be that participants believed the company put up the poster. In this case, it would make sense for participants to find no discrepancy between the person's displayed

ISC and their actions. The attribution of the environmental ISC to a different source may have ultimately reduced the possibility of finding a backlash effect.

Additionally, while we did not assess motives for putting up a poster or confronting bias, motives are important for perceptions of allyship behaviors (Chaney et al., *in press*; Chu & Ashburn-Nardo, 2022; Moser & Wiley, 2024; Radke et al., 2020; Thai & Nylund, 2024; Wilton et al., *in press*). One relevant and intriguing aspect of motives is that while one's motives, particularly regarding issues of bias and prejudice, can be difficult to know (Major et al., 2013; Rosenblum et al., 2022), racial minorities use attribution theory processes such as consistency (Kelley, 1973) to infer and draw conclusions about allies (Thai & Nylund, 2024). In our studies, behavior consistency was evident in the condition where the ISC and prejudice confrontation were both present. While we did not see this condition outperform the prejudice confrontation by itself, we would argue that seeing multiple cues that all align across time are valuable for reducing identity threat.

Constraints on Generality

This work was conducted in the U.S., and the meaning and cost of ISCs and prejudice confrontations may differ across cultural and sociopolitical contexts. Indeed, the ability to engage in direct confrontations is impacted by perceived social norms (Pereira-Jorge & Chaney, 2024), and thus the more liberal norms in the U.S. and broader Global North promote political correctness (i.e., norms against prejudice, discriminatory speech, or offensive views; Norris, 2021). These norms facilitate higher cost strategies despite the potential negative interpersonal consequences. In Global South and East Asian contexts, however, strategies like direct confrontation may be viewed as particularly high risk due to tighter norms around maintaining communal harmony (Lee et al., 2012). Thus, directly confronting someone about their attitudes may not be viewed as desirable or even an effective signal of ally sincerity. Our findings,

therefore, provide a starting point for expanding this work to other groups and locales. Future research could examine whether the perceived cost of ISCs is consistent across contexts, and whether individuals in different environments are more inclined to adopt lower cost strategies like signaling inclusion or utilize more indirect strategies.

Prior research also suggests that there is cultural variation in the extent to which people are motivated by self-enhancement, compared to self-effacement (Kitayama & Salvador, 2024), suggesting that the perceived authenticity of allyship behaviors may depend on cultural background. While the present work does not examine underlying motivations for displaying an ISC or confronting prejudice, recent work emphasizes the importance of motives within context (Louis et al., 2019; Ponce de Leon et al., 2024; Radke et al., 2020). For instance, the sincerity of an action may be judged based on whether it occurs in public or private. A higher cost strategy such as confronting prejudice might be seen as performative if carried out in the presence of others beyond the target of the confrontation. Future work should consider explicitly providing participants with information regarding ally motives for confronting (or not) and/or displaying an environmental ISC (or not). Indeed, this attribution of motive is important for understanding allyship behavior (Moser & Wiley, 2024; Nihill & Meyers, in press; Thai & Nylund, 2024), granted it is often difficult, if not impossible to know a person's true motives.

Other limitations of the current work apply to most studies that utilize hypothetical scenarios. For instance, we only used visually displayed posters even though there are other environmental ISCs such as diversity representation or pins on clothing (Derricks et al., 2022; Pietri et al., 2018; Purdie-Vaughns et al., 2008). Additionally, evidence suggests that the content of these cues matters for identity threat (Laiduc & Covarrubias, in press). While we attempted to keep the content of the posters similar across studies it is possible that the effectiveness of the environmental ISC differed, resulting in the inconsistent effects across Studies 1 and 2. For

instance, if Black participants viewed the poster as a more potent ISC, then this could account for why they had increased Bias Recognition, Perceived Allyship, and reduced Suspicion of Motives compared to the ISC only increasing Perceived Allyship for Asian American participants. We caution, however, that we did not design our studies to be explicitly comparative and rather sought to test two racial minority group members' reactions to generalize our findings. Future work could test different types of environmental ISCs to determine if some are more effective than others. Relatedly, we chose to use specific prejudicial remarks reliant on racial but also gendered stereotypes (i.e., STEM ability in Study 1 and driving in Study 2). While we found no consistent significant interactions with participant gender (see Supplemental Material for analyses), it should be noted that these remarks evoked gendered domains which might trigger intersectional stereotypes and prejudice (Ghavami & Peplau, 2012).

Conclusion

Environmental ISCs are used to signal identity safety, mitigate threat, and reduce marginalized group members' concerns that they will be the targets of bias and prejudice within a particular space (Kruk & Matsik, 2021). We show that U.S. racial minority group members, African Americans and Asian Americans, report reduced identity threat and increased ally sincerity when seeing a prejudice confrontation. Environmental ISCs are not to be ruled out since they are still effective compared to inaction. This research contributes to our understanding of how high- and low-cost prejudice reduction strategies operate in conjunction with each other, highlighting the importance of both in creating safe and inclusive climates.

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Table 1. Descriptive Means (*SDs*) for Studies 1 and 2 by Condition.

Figure 1. Images of the ISC Present/Confront Present conditions for Studies 1 and 2.

Figure 2. Results for Studies 1 (left) and 2 (right) for Perceived Allyship and Bias Recognition

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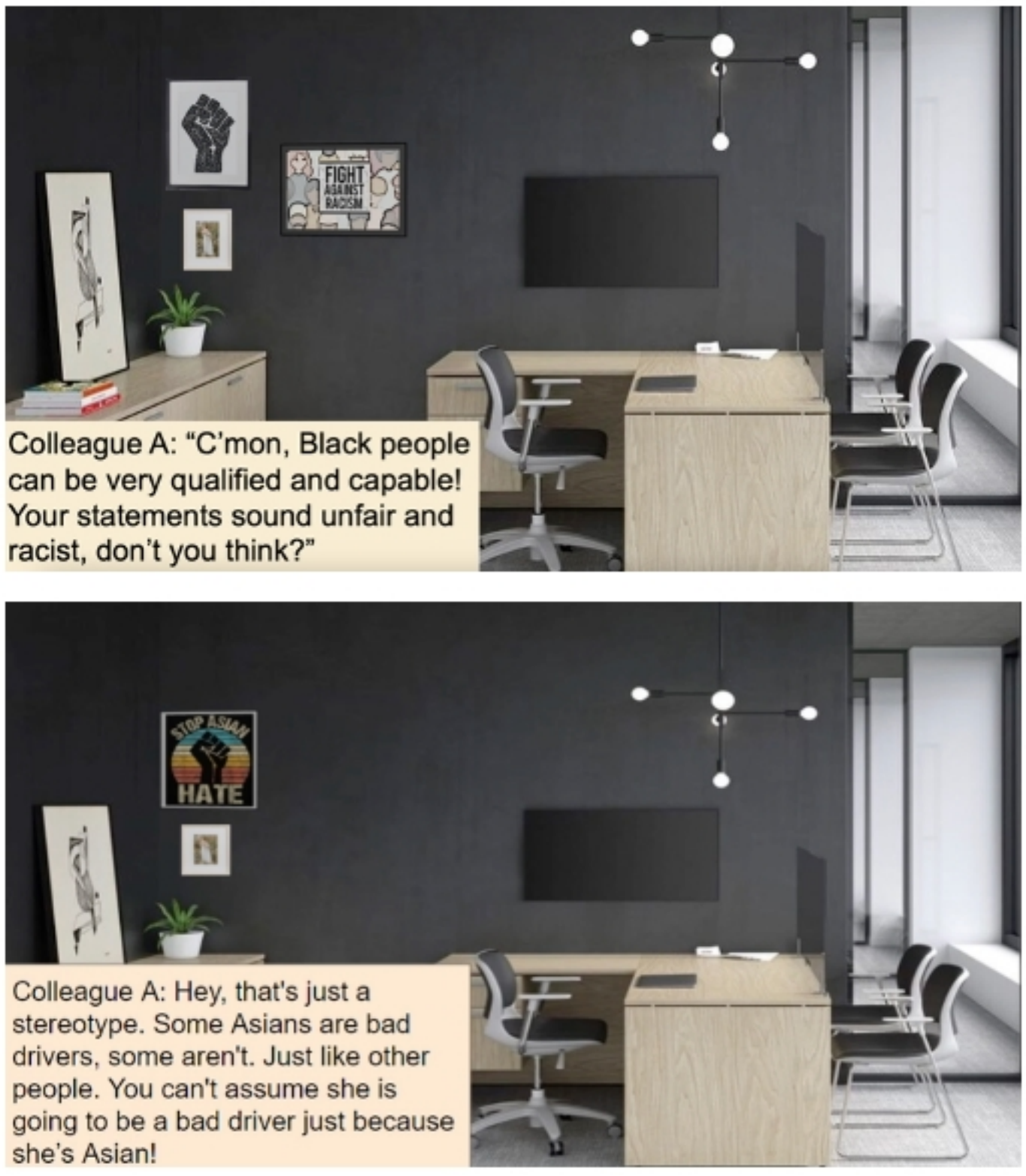

Figure 2. Results for Studies 1 (left) and 2 (right) for Perceived Allyship and Bias Recognition

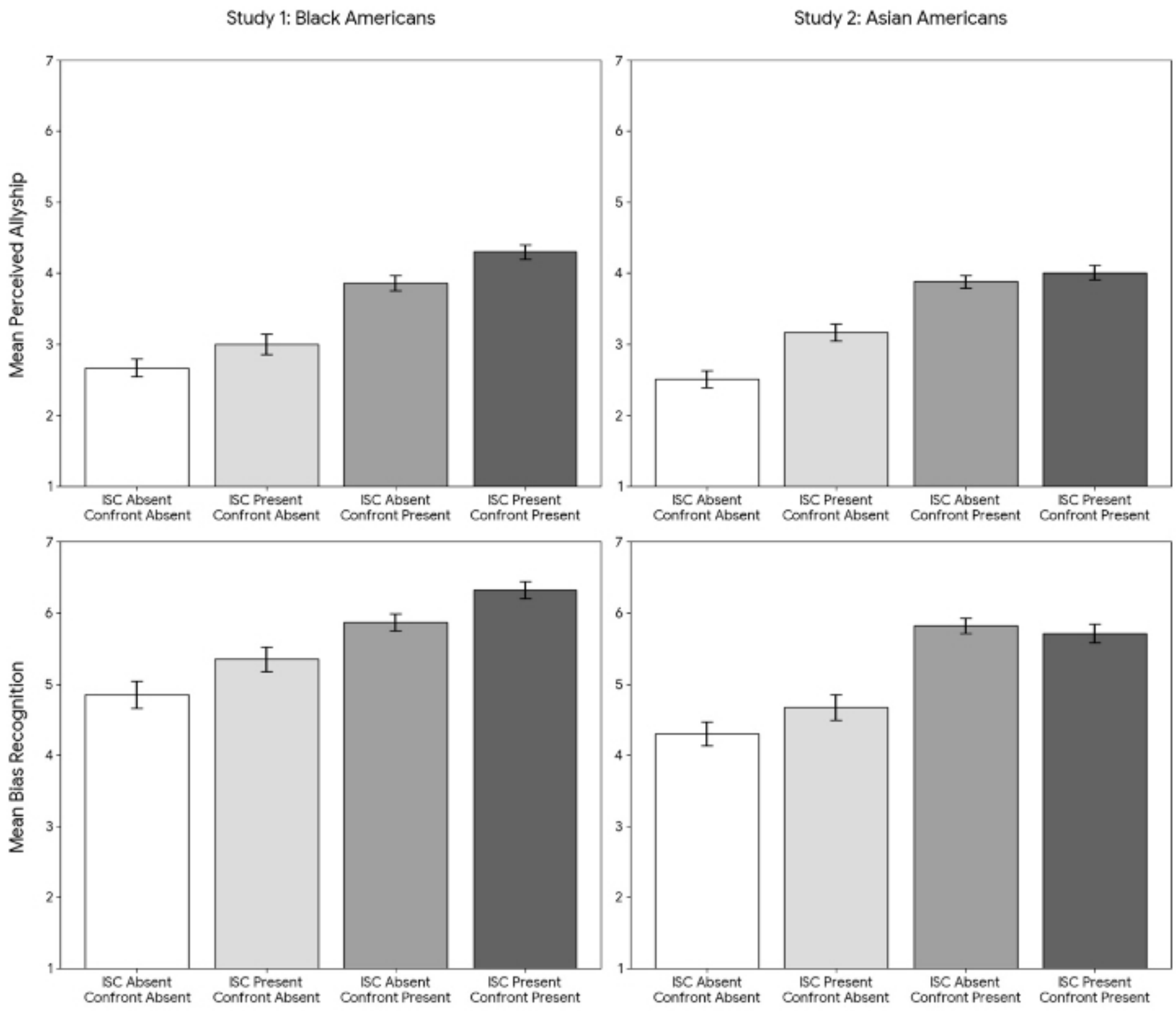

Table 1. Descriptive Means (*SDs*) for Studies 1 and 2 by Condition.

	ISC Present, Confront Absent	ISC Present, Confront Present	ISC Absent, Confront Present	ISC Absent, Confront Absent
Study 1 (Black Americans)				
Perceived Discrimination	3.44 (1.43)	2.24 (1.32)	2.36 (1.41)	3.79 (1.39)
Bias Recognition	5.35 (1.43)	6.32 (0.97)	5.87 (1.00)	4.85 (1.59)
Concern for Belonging	5.06 (1.58)	4.34 (1.52)	4.60 (1.50)	5.46 (1.31)
Diversity Dishonesty	4.79 (1.43)	3.00 (1.53)	3.33 (1.48)	5.12 (1.27)
Suspicion of Motives	0.59 (2.12)	-1.26 (1.82)	-0.56 (1.46)	1.15 (1.83)
Perceived Allyship	3.00 (1.22)	4.30 (0.87)	3.86 (0.91)	2.67 (1.04)
Study 2 (Asian Americans)				
Perceived Discrimination	3.32 (1.44)	2.38 (1.35)	2.01 (1.15)	3.10 (1.30)
Bias Recognition	4.67 (1.54)	5.71 (1.13)	5.82 (0.89)	4.30 (1.40)
Concern for Belonging	5.10 (1.50)	4.62 (1.36)	4.53 (1.28)	4.81 (1.52)
Diversity Dishonesty	4.63 (1.36)	3.21 (1.49)	2.95 (1.31)	4.50 (1.11)
Suspicion of Motives	0.80 (1.58)	-0.75 (1.81)	-0.65 (1.39)	0.52 (1.35)
Perceived Allyship	3.17 (1.03)	4.01 (0.85)	3.88 (0.79)	2.51 (0.96)

Supplemental Material for **Identity Safety Cues in the Context of Confronting Prejudice: Black Americans' and Asian Americans' Perceptions of Identity Threat and Ally Sincerity**

Pilot Study

We initially examined how U.S. White and Black participants perceived the use of low- (i.e., poster as an environmental ISC) and high-cost (i.e., prejudice confrontation) identity safety cues. We hypothesized that when a prejudice confrontation is missing, even with an environmental ISC present, participants would report more identity threat and less sincerity compared to when the prejudice confrontation and environmental ISC are both present and when only the prejudice confrontation is present. We also posited that this difference would be greater for Black Americans, compared to White Americans, because they are more often the targets of social identity threat and more vigilant to identity safety cues (Purdie-Vaughns et al., 2008).

Method

Participants

Power analyses in G*Power 3.1 (Faul et al., 2007) indicated a minimum of 256 participants to provide 80% power to detect an effect size of η_p^2 = .03. We recruited 259 participants through CloudResearch Connect (Hartman et al., 2023). Thirty participants were excluded for identifying as mixed-race Black-White, non-Black, or non-White or not providing their racial information. This left a sample of 229 (M_{age} = 29.93, SD_{age} = 4.76, 116 women, 110 men, and 3 gender unspecified; 120 White Americans, 109 Black Americans).

Procedure

After providing informed consent, participants were randomized into one of three conditions: ISC present/Confront present, ISC present/Confront absent, or ISC absent/Confront present. In each condition, participants viewed a short video and were told to imagine they were

a college student going to their professor's office to ask a question when they overheard a conversation between their professor and another professor. The video displayed the dialog, presented via text boxes (no audio) that appeared one at a time on the left or right of the screen with an indication of the speaker (e.g., Colleague O and Professor M). As the dialog played, the background showed a professor's office which either had or did not have an environmental ISC (i.e., a Black Lives Matter and a Stronger Together poster or no posters). In the dialog, Colleague O would make a prejudicial comment (i.e., "...It seems like we're letting in less-deserving students just for diversity's sake."), which Professor M would either confront (i.e., "...teaching with the belief that students of color are the cause of decreased exam scores can negatively affect their performance. Maybe you should check your assumptions…") or not (i.e., "It's only the first exam, there's plenty of time for improvement"). The dialog ended after this comment. After viewing the video, participants completed a manipulation check asking them to recall whether Colleague O's comment was confronted or not and whether an ISC was present or not. If participants failed this manipulation check, they viewed the video again. All participants successfully completed the manipulation check the second time. Participants then completed all measures and demographic information, viewed a debrief, and were compensated a small monetary sum.

Measures

We measured Identity Threat by assessing Perceived Discrimination, Bias Recognition, and Concern for Belonging and Ally Sincerity by assessing Diversity Dishonesty, Suspicion of Motives, and Perceived Allyship. All items were on a 1 = strongly disagree to 7 = strongly agree Likert scale. For correlations among measures see Supplemental Material (Supplemental Table 2).

Perceived Discrimination

We averaged five items assessing participants' judgments of Professor M as discriminatory (see Sanchez et al., 2017, "How likely is Professor M to discriminate against African Americans", α = .95).

Bias Recognition

We averaged three items assessing participants' beliefs that Professor M recognizes bias (see Johnson & Pietri, 2022, "Most likely, Prof. M is aware of discrimination facing racial minorities", α = .96).

Concern for Belonging

We averaged six items assessing Concern for Belonging (see Kroeper et al., 2022, "How much might you worry that you wouldn't belong in Prof. M's class", α = .96).

Diversity Dishonesty

We averaged three items assessing diversity dishonesty (see Wilton et al., 2020, "Professor M is dishonest about how much they do to support diversity and inclusion", α = .88).

Suspicion of Motives Index

We calculated the Suspicion of Motives Index (Major et al., 2013) by subtracting Perceived Internal Motives (e.g., "Please indicate how much you agree or disagree with why Prof. M decorates their office the way they do: Because they value diversity", α = .90) from Perceived External Motives ("...Because they want to appear more socially progressive", α = .80). In this case, higher scores indicate more external versus internal motives to appear non-prejudiced.

Perceived Allyship

We averaged two items assessing Perceived Allyship (see Pietri et al., 2018, " Prof. M cares about issues related to African Americans", r = .84).

Results

We conducted 2 (Participant Race: White or Black) by 3 (Condition: ISC present/Confront present, ISC present/Confront absent, ISC absent/Confront present) between-subjects ANOVAs. All follow-up comparisons used Bonferroni corrections. We hypothesized participants would report higher Identity Threat (i.e., higher perceived discrimination, concern for belonging and lower bias recognition) and lower Ally Sincerity (i.e., higher diversity dishonesty, suspicion of motives and lower perceived allyship) when an environmental ISC was present and no prejudice confrontation occurred, compared to the conditions with a prejudice confrontation. Additionally, we hypothesized a significant interaction between Race and Condition, with Condition differences stronger for Black compared to White participants. We report estimated marginal means and standard errors (see Supplemental Material (Supplemental Table 3) for means and standard deviations).

Identity Threat Measures

For Perceived Discrimination, results revealed no significant main effect of Participant Race, $F(1, 223) = 0.04$, $p = .846$, however there was a significant main effect of Condition, $F(2, 223) = 6.69$, $p = .002$, $\eta_p^2 = .06$. Results from follow-up comparisons showed that participants rated the ISC present/Confront present ($M = 2.11$, $SE = 0.19$) lowest in perceived discrimination, compared to ISC present/Confront absent ($M = 3.03$, $SE = 0.17$) and ISC absent/Confront present ($M = 2.75$, $SE = 0.18$), ps = .001 and .041 respectively. These last two conditions were not significantly different from each other, $p = .770$. This was qualified by a marginally significant interaction, $F(2, 223) = 2.61$, $p = .075$, $\eta_p^2 = .02$. While marginal, we broke down this interaction

by Participant Race. For White participants there was no significant difference across conditions, $F(2, 223) = 0.66$, $p = .519$, $\eta_p^2 = .01$. In contrast, for Black participants, there was a significant difference, $F(2, 223) = 8.34$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .07$. Follow-up comparisons revealed that the ISC present/Confront present condition ($M = 1.85$, $SE = 0.27$) was rated significantly lower than the ISC present/Confront absent ($M = 3.35$, $SE = 0.25$) and ISC absent/Confront present conditions ($M = 2.76$, $SE = 0.26$), ps < .001 and .048, respectively. The latter two conditions were not significantly different, $p = .293$.

Results for Bias Recognition revealed no significant main effect of Participant Race, $F(1, 223) = 0.88$, $p = .350$, however a significant main effect of Condition emerged, $F(2, 223) = 4.98$, $p = .008$, $\eta_p^2 = .04$. such that the ISC present/Confront absent condition ($M = 5.41$, $SE = 0.14$) was rated lower in Bias Recognition compared to the ISC present/Confront present ($M = 5.93$, $SE = 0.15$) and ISC absent/Confront present ($M = 6.00$, $SE = 0.14$) conditions, ps = .043 and .012, respectively. The latter two conditions were not significantly different from each other, $p = 1.00$. Again, a marginally significant interaction between Participant Race and Condition emerged, $F(2, 223) = 3.02$, $p = .051$, $\eta_p^2 = .03$. For White participants there was no significant difference across Condition, $F(2, 223) = 0.48$, $p = .619$, $\eta_p^2 = .004$, however there was for Black participants, $F(2, 223) = 7.24$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .06$, such that the ISC present/Confront absent condition ($M = 5.21$, $SE = 0.20$) was significantly lower on Bias Recognition than the ISC present/Confront present ($M = 6.22$, $SE = 0.22$) and ISC absent/Confront present ($M = 6.14$, $SE = 0.21$), ps = .003 and .005, respectively. The latter two conditions were not significantly different, $p = 1.00$.

Results for Concern for Belonging revealed a significant main effect of Participant Race, $F(1, 223) = 7.48$, $p = .007$, $\eta_p^2 = .03$ with White participants reporting lower scores ($M = 2.47$,

SE = 0.15) than Black participants (*M* = 3.06, *SE* = 0.16). There was also a significant main effect of Condition, $F(2, 223) = 4.58$, $p = .011$, $\eta_p^2 = .04$. The ISC present/Confront absent condition (*M* = 3.17, *SE* = 0.18) was rated significantly higher in Concern for Belonging compared to the ISC present/Confront present (*M* = 2.36, *SE* = 0.20), $p = .008$, but not the ISC absent/Confront present (*M* = 2.78, *SE* = 0.19) conditions, $p = .392$. The latter two conditions were not significantly different from each other, $p = .366$. There was no significant interaction between Participant Race and Condition, $F(2, 223) = 0.94$, $p = .391$.

Ally Sincerity Measures

Results for Diversity Dishonesty revealed no significant main effect of Participant Race, $F(1, 223) = .02$, $p = .904$, however a significant main effect of Condition emerged, $F(2, 223) = 9.66$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .08$. In this case, the ISC present/Confront absent condition (*M* = 4.15, *SE* = 0.17) was rated significantly higher in Diversity Dishonesty compared to the ISC present/Confront present (*M* = 3.16, *SE* = 0.18) and ISC absent/Confront present (*M* = 3.32, *SE* = 0.17) conditions, *p*s < .001 and .002, respectively. The latter two conditions were not significantly different from each other, $p = 1.00$. This was again qualified by a marginally significant interaction between Participant Race and Condition, $F(2, 223) = 2.63$, $p = .074$, $\eta_p^2 = .02$. There was no significant difference across the three conditions for White participants, $F(2, 223) = 2.33$, $p = .100$, $\eta_p^2 = .02$, however a significant difference for Black participants emerged, $F(2, 223) = 9.68$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .08$. Follow-up comparisons revealed that the ISC present/Confront absent condition (*M* = 4.38, *SE* = 0.24) was significantly higher on Diversity Dishonesty than the ISC present/Confront present (*M* = 2.83, *SE* = 0.26) and ISC absent/Confront present conditions (*M* = 3.41, *SE* = 0.25), *p*s < .001 and .017, respectively. The latter two conditions were not significantly different, $p = .340$.

Results for Suspicion of Motives Index revealed no significant main effect of Participant Race, $F(1, 223) = 0.45$, $p = .501$, however a significant main effect of Condition, $F(2, 223) = 7.20$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .06$. Here, the ISC present/Confront absent condition ($M = 0.10$, $SE = 0.23$) was rated significantly higher in Suspicion compared to the ISC present/Confront present ($M = -1.14$, $SD = 0.25$) and ISC absent/Confront present ($M = -0.79$, $SE = 0.23$) conditions, *p*s = .001 and .024, respectively. The latter two conditions were not significantly different from each other, $p = .889$. This was qualified by a significant interaction between Participant Race and Condition, $F(2, 223) = 4.52$, $p = .012$, $\eta_p^2 = .04$. Results showed no significant difference across conditions for White participants, $F(2, 223) = 0.17$, $p = .845$, $\eta_p^2 = .002$, however a significant difference for Black participants, $F(2, 223) = 11.11$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .09$, such that the ISC present/Confront absent condition ($M = 0.56$, $SE = 0.33$) was significantly higher on Suspicion than the ISC present/Confront present ($M = -1.68$, $SE = 0.36$) and ISC absent/Confront present ($M = -0.99$, $SE = 0.34$), *p*s < .001 and .004, respectively. The latter two conditions were not significantly different, $p = .508$.

Results for Perceived Allyship revealed a marginally significant main effect of Participant Race, $F(1, 223) = 3.79$, $p = .053$, $\eta_p^2 = .02$, with White participants having lower scores ($M = 3.77$, $SE = 0.09$) than Black participants ($M = 4.00$, $SE = 0.10$). There was also a significant main effect of Condition, $F(2, 223) = 7.63$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .06$. In this case, the ISC present/Confront absent condition ($M = 3.54$, $SE = 0.11$) was rated significantly lower in Perceived Allyship compared to the ISC present/Confront present ($M = 4.11$, $SE = 0.12$) and ISC absent/Confront present ($M = 4.05$, $SE = 0.11$) conditions, *p*s = .002 and .004, respectively. The latter two conditions were not significantly different from each other, $p = 1.00$. This time there

was no significant interaction between Participant Race and Condition, $F(2, 223) = 2.11$, $p = .124$.

Discussion

Results from the pilot study largely aligned with the hypothesis that when no prejudice confrontation occurs, participants would report higher Identity Threat (e.g., higher in perceived discrimination, lower in bias recognition, and higher concern for belonging) and lower Ally Sincerity (e.g., higher in diversity dishonesty, suspicion of motives, and lower in perceived allyship) even when an environmental ISC is present. While at best marginally statistically significant, interactions between Condition and Race revealed a consistent pattern whereby Black participants showed differences across conditions that aligned with the above pattern while White participants did not. Interestingly, only for Perceived Discrimination did results show a pattern whereby the dual use of both a prejudice confrontation and environmental ISC reduced beliefs that Prof. M would be discriminatory. Overall, our results suggest that when the confrontation of prejudice is missing, Black Americans in particular view this as a concern both for identity threat and ally sincerity. This study informed the design of Study 2.

Participant Gender Interactions in Studies 1 and 2

While not a pre-registered hypothesis as well as not a question of interest in our studies, we cautiously note that we found a few interactions with Participant Gender (coded as a binary of men and women with non-binary participants excluded). In Study 1, there was a statistically significant two-way interaction between ISC and Participant Gender for Perceived Discrimination, $F(1, 261) = 5.34$, $p = .022$, $\eta_p^2 = .02$. Breaking down this interaction by Gender, results showed a no simple main effect of ISC for men, $F(1, 261) = 0.96$, $p = .327$, $\eta_p^2 = .004$. There was, however, a simple main effect for women, $F(1, 261) = 6.01$, $p = .015$, $\eta_p^2 = .02$, such

that women rated the ISC present (M = 2.72, SE = 0.16) as lower in Perceived Discrimination than the ISC absent (M = 3.26, SE = 0.15). No other statistically significant interactions with Gender emerged.

For Study 2, there was a significant two-way interaction between Gender and ISC for Diversity Dishonesty, $F(1, 265) = 3.98$, $p = .047$, $\eta_p^2 = .02$. Breaking down this interaction by Gender, results showed no statistically significant simple main effect of ISC for women, $F(1, 265) = 0.58$, $p = .447$, $\eta_p^2 = .002$. There was, however, a statistically significant simple main effect of ISC for men, $F(1, 265) = 4.70$, $p = .031$, $\eta_p^2 = .02$, such that men rated the ISC present as higher in Diversity Dishonesty (M = 4.12, SE = 0.15) than ISC absent (M = 3.67, SE = 0.15) condition.

There was also a significant two-way interaction between Gender and ISC for Perceived Discrimination, $F(1, 265) = 6.21$, $p = .013$, $\eta_p^2 = .02$. Breaking down this interaction by Gender, result showed no statistically significant simple main effect of ISC for women, $F(1, 265) = 0.27$, $p = .606$, $\eta_p^2 = .001$. There was, however, a statistically significant simple main effect of ISC for men, $F(1, 265) = 10.32$, $p = .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .04$ such that men rated the ISC present as higher in Perceived Discrimination (M = 3.04, SE = 0.15) than the ISC absent (M = 2.37, SE = 0.14) condition.

These findings raise the possibility that for men, the ISC cue does create negative outcomes such that having the ISC leads to increased perceptions of Diversity Dishonesty and Perceived Discrimination compared to not having the ISC. Still, these effects are slightly inconsistent given they operate for only one out of the three outcomes measuring Identity Threat and Ally Sincerity. This may be an area for possible further exploration.

Supplemental Table 1. Intercorrelations across measures for Study 1 (above the diagonal) and 2 (below the diagonal)

	Perceived Discrimination	Bias Recognition	Concern for Belonging	Diversity Dishonesty	Suspicion of Motives	Perceived Allyship
Perceived Discrimination	—	-.39	.27	.71	.61	-.72
Bias Recognition	-.52	—	-.07	-.40	-.33	.53
Concern for Belonging	.33	-.12	—	.36	.31	-.35
Diversity Dishonesty	.64	-.38	.30	—	-.68	-.73
Suspicion of Motives	.49	-.36	.18	.59	—	-.65
Perceived Allyship	-.60	.62	-.21	-.59	-.54	—

Supplemental Table 2. Intercorrelations across measures for Pilot Study

	Perceived Discrimination	Bias Recognition	Concern for Belonging	Diversity Dishonesty	Suspicion of Motives	Perceived Allyship
Perceived Discrimination	—					
Bias Recognition	-.62	—				
Concern for Belonging	.65	-.42	—			
Diversity Dishonesty	.66	-.57	.54	—		
Suspicion of Motives	.51	-.58	.44	.65	—	
Perceived Allyship	-.72	.74	-.51	-.67	-.61	—

Supplemental Table 3. Descriptive Means (*SDs*) for Race by Condition for Pilot Study.

	White			Black		
	ISC Present Confront Absent	ISC Present Confront Present	ISC Absent Confront Present	ISC Present Confront Absent	ISC Present Confront Present	ISC Absent Confront Present
Perceived Discrimination	2.71 (1.63)	2.38 (1.28)	2.75 (1.67)	3.35 (1.74)	1.85 (1.08)	2.76 (1.70)
Bias Recognition	5.61 (1.23)	5.63 (1.54)	5.86 (1.21)	5.21 (1.51)	6.22 (0.97)	5.86 (1.21)
Concern for Belonging	2.83 (1.73)	2.26 (1.47)	2.32 (1.58)	2.26 (1.47)	2.45 (1.53)	3.23 (1.75)
Diversity Dishonesty	3.94 (1.63)	3.50 (1.61)	3.24 (1.58)	3.51 (1.71)	2.83 (1.21)	3.41 (1.52)
Suspicion of Motives	-0.37 (2.05)	-0.61 (2.34)	-0.58 (2.04)	0.56 (2.15)	-1.68 (2.16)	-0.99 (1.70)
Perceived Allyship	3.60 (0.95)	3.86 (1.11)	3.85 (1.18)	3.47 (1.20)	4.35 (0.70)	4.26 (0.72)

OXY Occidental College

March 23, 2026

Dear Drs. Chaney, Oswald, and Matsick,

My co-authors and I are submitting a copy of the revised manuscript, "**Identity Safety Cues in the Context of Confronting Prejudice: Black Americans' and Asian Americans' Perceptions of Identity Threat and Ally Sincerity"** to be considered for publication in the Special Issue "Identity Safety Cues in Context: How Group Status, Interpersonal Dynamics, and Systemic Events Impact Perceptions of Identity Safety Cues" in the *Journal of Social Issues.*

This revision made the minor changes suggested by the Editor.

This work has not been submitted for publication at another journal and has not already been published elsewhere. All participants in this research were treated in accordance with APA guidelines on ethical treatment of human subjects in research. Studies reported in this paper were approved by the authors' Institutional Review Board.

Thank you for considering this manuscript.

Sincerely,
Authors

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